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Virginia Board of Education, Work Session, Wednesday, September 13, 2023

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UnLAFvV4F0I
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-23. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:13:58] - Everyone, I would like to go ahead and call our session to order. Can you give me just a minute before we go into CASE to take care of, I need to take care of a housekeeping matter.

[00:14:18] - Go ahead and call our session to order. Can you give me just a minute before we go into CASE? - That's right. - And what do I do?

[00:14:30] We'll take care of everyone now is a matter of housekeeping.

[00:17:52] I've asked the RAG Council to give us some ways that we may be able to adjudicate cases a little bit more efficiently and effectively. And so they are going to be coming to us with some recommendations that are obviously well within the law.

[00:18:13] Cases that are petitioner cases have to come to us, but cases that are applicant cases, we are able to do have some more flexibility with. And so next month, I've asked that the AG Council bring us some recommendations on how we can work through a lot of these cases that we're seeing

[00:18:33] a little bit more easily, number one, but also to provide us a little bit of just some breathing room to be able to get our work done a little bit more effectively so that we can hasten the process for those who do have to come before the board for any licensure matters.

[00:18:56] So just wanted to give everybody that information before we went into closed session. And with that, Mr. Hansen, I will ask for your motion, please. I move that the Virginia Board of Education convene in a closed meeting for the following purposes, discussion or consideration by the Board of Education of information relating to the denial, suspension, or revocation of teacher licenses subject to the exclusion

[00:19:23] in subdivision 11 of section 2.2-3705.2, pursuant to section 2.2-377A40 of the Code of Virginia in consultation with council regarding specific legal matters requiring the provision of legal advice pursuant to Virginia code section 2.2-377A8 of the Virginia code and the legal counsel to the Virginia board of education and staff whose presence will aid in the board's

[00:19:56] consideration of this matter participate in the closed meeting so move all those in favor

[00:20:07] indicate by saying aye aye and we are in closed session now in a closed meeting pursuant to a

[02:48:28] recorded vote on the motion of above and in accordance with the freedom information act section 2.2-3712 of the code of virginia requires of the board certify that to the best of each member's knowledge only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements under this chapter and only such public business matters as were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened, were heard, discussed, or considered. Any member who believes there was a departure from these requirements shall so state prior to the vote, indicating the

[02:49:04] substance of the departure that, in his or her judgment, has taken place. The statement of the departure will be recorded in the minutes. Okay. Ms. Kilgore, closed session. Yes. Ms. Holton?

[02:49:21] Yes. Dr. Siebert? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Ms. Ashton? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. And chair votes aye. Okay. The chair will entertain a motion in case number two to issue a license to the applicant. We moved. Okay, I didn't hear. Okay.

[02:49:55] Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Ms. Holton? Aye. Dr. Siebert? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Ms. Ashton? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Mr. Rotherham? Aye. Chair votes aye. the chair will entertain a motion to issue a license to the applicant in case number three miss kilgore oh i'm sorry i need a second uh miss kilgore um miss holton no um dr siebert hi mr

[02:50:29] hansen hi miss ashton hi dr northern hi mr rotherham yes um and chair votes i okay see the chair will entertain a motion to defer action in case number six second miss kilgore miss holton hi dr siebert

[02:50:57] hi mr hanson hi miss ashton hi dr northern hi mr rotherham chair votes aye um okay the chair will entertain a motion in case number seven to deny a renewed license to keith nolan morgan so moved second miss kilgore miss holton hi dr siebert hi mr hanson hi miss ashton hi dr northern hi mr

[02:51:33] rotherham and chair votes i okay the chair will entertain a motion to revoke the license of marissa lynn gray so moved second miss kilgore hi miss holton no dr siebert hi mr hanson hi miss ashton aye Dr. Northern aye Mr. Rotherham aye and chair votes aye okay um the chair will entertain a

[02:52:11] motion to revoke the license of Holly Lorraine Kraft Ms. Kilgore aye Ms. Holton aye Dr. Siebert aye Mr. Hansen aye Ms. Ashton aye Dr. Northern aye Mr. Rotherham and chair votes aye okay the chair will entertain a motion to revoke the license of cassandra lee kilpatrick also known as

[02:52:41] cassandra leak lake home second miss kilgore ah miss holton hi dr siebert hi mr hansen miss ashton hi dr northern hi mr rotherham and chair votes aye okay thank you to the office of

[02:53:05] professional practices we appreciate your service to the commonwealth thank you thank you okay um if we can go ahead and move to item a a closed session for legal updates please i will

[02:53:35] entertain a motion um from mr hansen i got the current um we'll just do this one so keep this part and then only that i move that the virginia board of education convene in a closed meeting for the following purposes consultation with council regarding specific legal matters requiring the provision of legal advice pursuant to virginia code section 2.2-3711 a8 of the code of virginia

[02:54:13] and the legal counsel to the virginia board of education staff whose presence will aid in the board's consideration of this matter participate in the closed meeting um all those in favor of

[02:54:28] moving into closed session please indicate by saying aye aye who's doing are we today in a

[03:34:13] closed meeting pursuant to a recorded vote on the motion above in accordance with the freedom information act section 2.2-3712 of the code of virginia requires that the board certify that to the best of each member's knowledge only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements under this chapter and only public business matters as were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened were heard discussed or considered any member who believes there was a departure from these requirements shall so state prior to the vote indicating the substance of the departure that in his or her judgment has taken place

[03:34:51] statement of the departure will be recorded in the minutes so move the certification second Ms. Fulton? Aye. Dr. Siebert? Aye. Mr. Hanson? Aye. Ms. Ashton? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Ms. Rotherham?

[03:35:07] And chairperson? Aye. Okay we are going to take a 30-minute lunch break so we will be back at 12:50

[03:35:16] and we can start early on the work sessions. Ladies and gentlemen we are back um and we are

[04:11:52] ready to move to item b please and so that would be Mr. Dickey. Good afternoon President Creasy, members of the board dr coons um just a brief presentation for you today um some quick um updates and an overview on school facilities issues uh in virginia but primarily to update you and and inform you on our our plans uh for your study requirements under senate bill 1124

[04:12:25] uh which are uh significant that's legislation of course that um passed at the 2023 session related to um requirements uh to make recommendations to the general assembly uh to amend the soq related to school facilities um issues um very quickly um just just to um provide some context on the magnitude of school infrastructure and facilities, in regards to school facilities in Virginia,

[04:13:01] you see the number of buildings in the school divisions, about 2,000. That number is probably a bit higher with some of the district and regional centers that are in standalone facilities, probably 100 more of those types of buildings that have to be maintained or modernized and operated so the number of public school buildings is north of 2000 in the state and in that second bullet uh you can see um this is of course a very significant uh area of expense for localities

[04:13:40] on fy 22 uh over a billion and uh school capital cost uh approaching two billion in operations and maintenance costs to keep for upkeep and operations and maintenance of existing buildings, almost $700 million in debt service costs for past debt on school facilities, and then over $10 billion in outstanding debt on school facilities were supported in FY22. So, of course, a very significant area of expense and funding for local governments and school divisions.

[04:14:15] and with that in mind the general assembly governor of course um provided um really unprecedented levels of of state funding uh in the in the current budget uh as you know both grants uh and and literary fund loans and that came in the form of um two grant programs the the formula program of 400 million that that money uh flowed last year to school uh school divisions so got out in the field for school facilities use of course your competitive grants program that

[04:14:53] you're responsible for you have guidelines to operate the competitive grant program 450 million dollars you've awarded 365 million dollars in those competitive grants to date later this month will be running another application round for the remaining $85 million. That's coming in a couple of weeks. An announcement to school divisions. Lastly, you've been issuing and approving literary funds from the $400 million in loan authorization that's in the current budget. We've approved

[04:15:33] $153 million in applications. You've issued or released $41 million in loans, and we continue to bring those every month to you when they're ready to go. In fact, we'll be running a second round application process for the Literary Fund later this month as well. And then your study requirements under Senate Bill 1124. We're beginning the process to support you in that study and those study requirements. And of course, the recommendations that have to be

[04:16:12] delivered to the education committees by July 124. Chief of Staff Raley is convening a work group uh those invitations have gone out uh we're looking at an initial meeting uh september or in october uh doesn't look like we'll be able to get that initial meeting in this month but we'll we'll have a kickoff meeting with the work group uh in october and we've got a broad stakeholder group we've invited to participate uh throughout the winter and fall um major uh state education groups

[04:16:50] uh vml vaco principals groups parent representatives uh subject matter experts in the school facilities industry architects uh some of the national school facilities organizations have been invited to participate so we we feel like we've got a broad range secretary's office of course we'll have a representative and and invite your participation um as appropriate as well so Chief of Staff Raley has kicked off that process and were in the process of booking the first work group meeting.

[04:17:26] Very quickly, these are the four main provisions of the study legislation, fairly broad areas of recommendations in terms of building maintenance and operations, renovation, construction. The second bullet, which is a key piece that was studied by the Commission on School Construction Modernization the last couple of years, is a percentage holdback in local budgets for operation and maintenance and to maintain building value, especially given the increased state investment in school facilities.

[04:18:05] That will be a key piece of review and study. Then the third bullet, of course, again, I've described the work group representation that we're putting together, and we plan for public comment to be part of the process.

[04:18:22] We'll meet fall and winter timeframe in the work group for research and analysis. spring timeframe will be dedicated to developing recommendations to bring to the board in the mid-late spring. And then ultimately, of course, your final deadline to deliver recommendations is July 124. So we look forward to working with you on the process. The very last slide as I finish up,

[04:18:55] These are illustrative, preliminary, just a review of literature and some input subject matter experts and DOE staff, some possible areas of inquiry for the work group and for you and developing

recommendations.

[04:19:12] And really, we're thinking of it in three batches, planning and standards for building, planning and design, standards for construction and renovation, and then post-construction operation and maintenance. And you see some of the themes and topics that could be explored in this non-exhausted list.

[04:19:37] So with that, Madam President, overview of your study requirements, 11-24. Do you have any questions? Thank you, Mr. Dickey.

[04:19:54] This is a monumental task, and we would be lost without you. So thank you. Can you give us some idea of the timeline for when you expect the matter? It has to be done by July 1. when do you expect the matter to come before us? At what stage and when in the calendar between now and July will we? Yeah, we would certainly want to bring recommendations, draft recommendations as early as possible in the spring, you know, given, you know, there may need to be multiple

[04:20:29] reviews. That could be as early as April or May, you know, to stay on track for the July 1 deadline for submission of General Assembly. Even though we don't usually meet in May, unless our schedule changes for next year, we would meet in April. Yeah, that's correct. And probably a cadence of April. April to June. And then that means that we may not hear from you again before April. So I don't know whether this is not something that I have any real area of expertise on, but if there were a sentiment on the board to want to have input

[04:21:04] earlier on in the, before you come to us with a set of recommendations, would we need to schedule something in what time frame? Certainly, I, you know, perhaps, let's say, you know, January meeting, correct? Maybe the February time frame for an update. January. And if I've always understood, I mean, I think this may just be history rather than written down, but that we always,

[04:21:36] The historical expectation is localities build schools, a state, I don't know, does the state historically contribute to maintenance and operations at all? Are we more contributing? SOQs haven't previously addressed either new construction or operations and maintenance?

[04:21:56] Well, what the SOQ doesn't provide is capital support. It does provide fairly substantial operation and maintenance funding in the support area. and that that's you know on the order of about half a billion a year and our school divisions spend more than that that's what's in our existing soqs there is something in our existing soqs but it's really it's really deemed maintenance repair operations not capital improvements but there is so currently the state does contribute to some percentage of local of the locals um expenditure

[04:22:32] we do contribute to the cost of maintenance and operation through the existing soq that's correct relatively low level okay and we haven't traditionally contributed to new construction except by special allocations like the one you've you know historically over the last 30 or 4 years 30 or 40 years you know fairly sporadic and periodic and periodic special issues yeah this biennium being the exception this study potentially could lead to an alteration of that dynamic between the state and the localities on construction funds for instance hopefully it will

[04:23:11] certainly you know inform some of those issues it will help inform whether or not they want okay thank you mr rotherham did you have a question yeah i did thank you for this um it was going to make sense and i don't want to put the car before the horse is there going to be an opportunity I mean, a

lot of this stuff seems a cross-cutting theme here would be sustainability, sort of, you know, thinking about efficiency, energy, all of those things.

[04:23:37] Like, where is that going to be explicitly called out? Or where do stakeholders who have an interest in that particular issue want to make sure we're using this as potentially a step forward? Schools do use a lot of energy. Where will they be able to engage in the process? Or what will, like, cross-cutting issues like that look like?

[04:23:54] Yeah, Mr. Rothfairman, I think some of the membership in the work group will certainly bring that expertise and input, but we would always invite input, you know, in that particular area.

[04:24:11] But we think some of the subject matter folks, architects, school facilities, professionals will bring some of that, and there is an existing, it's more aspirational in my read of it, but a current code provision that does encourage positive energy type construction design in school buildings, but we've flagged that as a topic area to explore.

[04:24:40] Right. And my colleague knows something I've been interested in on this board for a long time is more avenues for student voice. And so this also seems like a place where, particularly on that sustainability issue, a lot of students, there's a lot, you see a lot of sustainability clubs in the high schools around the state and so forth. They're in environmental clubs and different things, and they're interested in this, and it could be an opportunity for some student engagement or even an opportunity for students to participate.

[04:25:04] Good point. We'll certainly note that. Anyone else? Thank you, Mr. Thank you. So at this time, my microphone will work. At this time, I think we are looking for Dr. Armstrong, since we're going to skip it over C and move to D.

[04:25:37] Dr. Solari wasn't planning on being here until 1.20, 1.30. We're just flying through. Yes, yes. Thank you, Dr. Armstrong, for being flexible. Thank you all.

[04:25:52] It's also my first time using the technology, so bear with me. All right. There we go. Pretty straightforward. Great.

[04:26:10] Good afternoon, Madam President and board members. It's great to be with you all this afternoon. I'm Andy Armstrong, the new Assistant Superintendent of Strategic Innovation in my fifth week here. So what I want to discuss with you today is in consideration that I'm really just dipping our toe in the water, I think, at this point.

[04:26:29] And I've been engaged with collaborating with our agency staff, with some of the educators and partners from across the Commonwealth to really inform this work that we're doing to make engaging pathways for all learners here, especially at the high school level, and to rethink what that looks like for our students in Virginia.

[04:26:49] I was a middle and high school principal for 10 years here in Virginia, a product of these public schools, and I'm passionate about this work. So for today, I'd like to talk specifically about the four dimensions as you all consider the accountability system of what our work is really involved in and is in progress on right now.

[04:27:10] Those are our early post-secondary opportunities, industry-recognized credentials, making those meaningful. We'll get into more detail about that. College readiness and military readiness. And we

recognize a lot of these dimensions already included in our current accountability system and how can we make it more meaningful? How can we really support the work to make this outcome-driven when it comes to doing the good work on behalf of our high school students here in Virginia? Let's start with early post-secondary opportunities. I think the work that we're doing in this, a lot of these current opportunities are already in existence for our students here

[04:27:49] in Virginia. AP, dual enrollment, has proliferated a great bit in the past decade. IP programs. A little more details needed, I think, about the Cambridge examinations. 880 universities in the country accept Cambridge credit. And I'm personally, I am not that familiar with Cambridge examinations, the impact that could have.

[04:28:08] Along with CLEP, I think a lot of us have heard the term CLEP, but again, not as frequently seen in the offerings that we have for our high school students. So just some things that we want to dig in more on to make sure that we're providing what we can for our students here in our Virginia high schools. For our meaningful industry-recognized credentials, this is the area that has probably received the most attention from me along with the partnership with our CT director, Dr. Williams.

[04:28:34] And I will tell you that even before I arrived, work was really in progress to evaluate what our credentials were and to make sure that we're satisfying that italicized word there and making our credentials meaningful. And how can we expand access to those credentials, but more importantly, how do we really filter down over 300 that we have now to ensure that what we do include and recognize is meaningful. That's aligned with labor market data that we have here in the Commonwealth, even regionally. How do we collect data about that? And Dr. Williams and his team are already developing a prototype rubric

[04:29:10] to look at credentials that we currently have in existence and then to bring our business and industry partners to the table to get feedback on that as well. So we're going to continue to evaluate that, and then subsequently provide transparent reporting about the outcomes related to those credentials. Preparing for college success. How can this, in our work here in Virginia, reduce the need for remediation for our students? We find that there is a proportion of our graduates who attend college and enroll in a free university who require some type of remediation when they get to college. How can we really, first of all, establish reliable data around that, then support

[04:29:47] any adaptation. We have our curriculum and our practice to support that and to hopefully avoid that in the future and continue to transparently report that data as well. Our military readiness. Virginia is one of the top five states in the nation for active duty reserve members and home to 27 military bases. So how can we continue to support the interest and preparation for career in the armed services here in Virginia, including ASVAB, but not just including ASVAB, but making a clear, thoughtful line about where that task score is. What's the outcome related to ASVAB?

[04:30:22] That's really going to be a predictor for success in preparation for the military service. And expanding those partnerships to our JRTC units, which are existing resources we have here in the Commonwealth. So that's just a very brief overview of those four broad areas that we're really focusing our work in right now. Key questions, we've mentioned this before, is do we have the data we need? Can we make informed decisions? And that's not just happening here in the agency.

[04:30:48] That is among various levels and systems as well. And does that accreditation model reflect our strategic priorities? Whoops, lost one. So there you go. Just some next steps that we have. I'll take

anybody's questions and refer to Dr. Coons as well for comments.

[04:31:12] Maddie, I'm sorry, Dr. Norther. So I know we're going to talk about this a little bit later as well. I'm just circling. The college readiness measure will include, I'm assuming, ACT and SAT scores because that's our typically used measure. Yes, that's the traditional measure. And that's also, I think, a function of that readiness piece when it comes to remediation. There's got to be data out there about if you're achieving at a certain level, is that going to be more predictive of your remediation needs when you get to college? But absolutely, we'll be a part of that readiness

[04:31:49] the syndicator. Yeah, we got so much opt out with those now being, you know, some wondering how we're going to handle that, but that's for another day. And also these EPSOs, I assume that includes apprenticeships and work-based learning opportunities? It does. And I did separate out the credential part of that, but yes, the service learning, work-based learning that I know we typically include under that EPSO will be included in that as well. Okay, awesome. And in terms of the IRCs, I think, and it sounds like you guys are going to do a lot of good, you know,

[04:32:25] discussion around this, but at some point, I think what you're saying is we'll have a quote approved list, then those will be the only ones that they'll be getting credit for in the CCR. Okay. Thank you. We have had presentations from ACT and SAT, and there's a significant decline in Virginia of use of either one. So if that were going to be part of this, there'd be a shift we would have to make around ACT and SAT. I just want to make sure the board is aware. In some states, they have a statewide use of ACT or SAT. There was a pretty good mix four or five years ago in

[04:33:05] Virginia. There's a significant decline on both assessments right now in test takers and test goers in the way in which they're using ACT and SAT as high school. And then on the industry recognized credential, there is a cross-functioning task force with Secretary Slater, Secretary Gadara, and the Ed Department to really look at industry recognized credentials with businesses, with industry to determine what are the ones that our business and industry need to see and how that and informs what would be recognized for high school.

[04:33:39] - Fulton. - So on the credentials list, it's not that we don't have a list, it's that we have a list. - Yes, yes. - It's very long. And essentially, if a fairly loose inclusion process may be perhaps driven by the commercial outfits that offer the credential testing.

[04:34:07] At least that, you know, they come as an applicant and jump through certain hoops and end up on the list. So it's well, it's 300 or some. - Yeah, over 300. And I will tell you, I visited Burden Tech out near Dr. Seibert's old stomping grounds in Roanoke County last week and had this conversation with their CT director and the region six CT folks and talked about that.

[04:34:30] And I think it's really making sure that we're, yes, establishing a list of meaningful credentials, but not reducing opportunities for engagement. Let's be clear about that. So while there may be some coursework that might not lead to a credential, it doesn't mean that it might not be engaging for students. I think our current career readiness indicator is not just the credential.

[04:34:53] You have taken two courses in a sequence and passed the credential test. And so if you tighten up the credential list, I hope you will also come back to us with recommendations. Is that structure still appropriate or is there something else we should do?

[04:35:08] we had some public comment from some folks recommending that we look at revising that structure. I think that came in in the public comment for today's board meeting. So that might be worth taking a look at. Yes, absolutely. And I think it's great you're going to have conversations with the business community. Work-based learning is currently one way to count in the numerator, so to speak, for the career readiness indicator. And I don't see that on your list. So I hope that's something we're going to make a thoughtful decision about.

[04:35:43] That will continue to be captured. It's just a matter of where do we fit that in to make the most sense, I think, and what our indicator is. Where it fits in now is one of a number of ways that a student can be in the numerator for the career readiness indicator. And quality work-based learning is not limited to just CTE exposure. You can get work-based learning experiences And the department has put out some, maybe it was the board, put out some fairly clear guidelines about what work-based learning does currently count towards the CCRI, if I remember.

[04:36:16] Yes, and we're going to evaluate that as well. Good, good. And on the ACT-SAT, it is not currently one of the criteria by which a student can count as having had a being career ready or college or career ready.

[04:36:36] Would one option be to make it another option, you know, states, Dr. Coons, that I don't know how other states are using it, but the fact that we've got declining percentage would be a reason not to use it as our sole criteria, perhaps.

[04:36:52] But, you know, a healthy passing score might be considered another route to being considered college ready alongside options of dual enrollment, etc. I'll make sure Chad is able to speak to ACT and SAT tomorrow.

[04:37:11] From my understanding, states either use it or they don't. So they use it as a statewide measure or they don't use it as a statewide measure. It's pretty binary because of, as we talked about with formative assessments, whether it's, you know, iReady or one of those other formative assessments that use for growth correlating across is very challenging.

[04:37:32] So one of the things we have heard about C-C-R-I through this accountability phase and very clearly from superintendents and from VAS is that it's very hard to manage and it's very complex. And having them an SAT option alongside multiple other options might just make it even more complicated.

[04:37:53] I have heard singular frustration around that right now. It's not as simple as a numerator-denominator. Right now, it is a numerator or denominator issue, but the ways you get into the numerator are multiple, and that's a tracking issue, I assume, for the divisions. And that reminds me, on the military one, right now, what we have, well, remind me what we have now.

[04:38:14] Is it taking the ASVAB, you get credit in the numerator, but you don't have to achieve at a certain level? My understanding is it's just that. You take the ASVAB and you sit for it, and we don't have necessarily an output score that represents spreading.

[04:38:30] So we do include as, we include something sort of like the credentials. If you participate in JROTC and take the ASVAB, then you count as career ready. That was a question that came up in my meeting with the Region 6 CT folks last week.

[04:38:46] They were asking about how to count the ASVAB. So that's another point to consider. If what I just, so I think what I hear you saying is what we might do is make it more restrictive to say, in addition to participating in JROTC and taking the test, you have to actually get a decent score on the test. Yes, and restrictive. I don't know if I'd call it restrictive, but we want to at least set an outcome, clear expectation. Well, it would be if right now there's no test score required, then just take showing up for the test, get you on the list, and we would be narrowing that pool, maybe restricting that the right one. And then all of

[04:39:25] That makes me really, the discussion we're having with Chad tomorrow about career readiness indicator is sort of looking at what's going on in elsewhere in the country, but comparing what's going on in Virginia, what we are already using and thinking about how we get from where we are to where we want to be, you're involved, your operation will intersect with Chad's operation?

[04:39:47] Yes, it will. Yes. thank you are we still using the career readiness test or is that it was a state career readiness test and if you passed it it was a credential to put on your diploma it was and i believe that is still in use there are and that's an example of i hope it's strengthened right i'm retired cte teacher so i'm familiar with that and i saw the the you know the necessity for it but i felt like it did some tweaking and that's a perfect example of a a test and assessment does that really would you consider that to be a credential that's going to pay off for you in the workplace or about soft

[04:40:25] skills a lot of it was right which are important absolutely and the industry says that they said that was a that was one of the things they i know at the time when they developed it was that students were not coming in they may be trained in the hard skills or whatever is there but they were lacking sorely in the soft skills but i just wonder that was i've been out of two years i didn't know that Absolutely, that is still in our list of potentials, but I can double-check them out for you.

[04:40:53] Dr. Siebert. And Dr. Armstrong, we're glad you're here, and it's good to see you. And I understand that work was being done before you arrived, and now we're talking about the headwaters of some of this, to be kind of candid. So in a minute, I'm going to ask you if you maybe have like a tentative timeline of like what some next actions would be, where we could expect some stuff.

[04:41:11] But to give you a minute to think about that, I just want to lift something up for my colleagues on the board. dual enrollment is a powerful indicator and is a tremendous opportunity it is a real gateway for young people um it also there there there is a challenge there for for some school divisions because to to have teachers who can often divisions divisions already pick teachers from each other just because you know that's what happens because we're in a shortage but it especially happens with dual enrollment teachers because you have to have the masters in the content area plus 15 hours and um and and that makes you now you can teach the community college and and and not have to deal

[04:41:47] with a whole bunch of things um also then you're kind of in demand for that content area for that credential so if it's going to come we're going to elevate its role in the system as we think about soq and funding all those kinds of things we need to probably think about dual enrollment credentials pathways to people getting them supporting some support divisions who maybe don't have the opportunity to offer as much dual enrollment as others i mean they truly the normal systems already improved for a while it was like let's do everything we can it really has come back to what are the things that are part of the passport so that that's that that's all very strengthening but we have a teacher shortage and as we have a teacher shortage we have an even more acute

[04:42:25] qualified to teach to enrollment shortage so i just think we need to be mindful of that and with implications that some some of our more most disadvantaged students have the least opportunity because they've got school divisions that are having the hardest time hiring teachers qualified to teach dual enrollment classes i think and those dual enrollments are mandated by higher ed and higher ed accreditation so there's not much we can control over what makes a dual enrollment teacher and a lot is allowability because that's actually not controlled by k-12 so we have had multiple conversations with the community college and david dory about ways to think through that

[04:43:04] and ways we could do that they have some ideas we have some ideas as well but um funding those kinds of things are as you all know more challenging than just simply um doing that it it is something we are looking through and trying to figure out um fiscally a big challenge with shores so my president hopefully gave andy dr armstrong a minute to think about um what what what are some of the mile posts uh that you see ahead of us and when and before i answer that i do want to say too that what you mentioned dr sybert about the teacher shortage licensure issues and that affects ap as well you have varied access to ap offerings from division to division

[04:43:44] and we don't want to exacerbate that either so something to consider as for the timelines i did not have that ready for you but that is something that we are working to accomplish in short order the credential question is probably the most complex and dr williams and i have already met on several occasions about that he's got a rubric ready to go he was talking about presenting that sometimes winter but we can accelerate that as need be and we have to coordinate with the other secretariats to do that because one of the pieces of that industry recognized credential component in that matrix is making sure that we've coordinated with um secretary slater and

[04:44:22] making sure that we're coordinating with workforce and getting workforce input about which credentials are most important in the high wage high demand fields across the state so it's going to take a few different settings to get that industry recognized credential list into the right place. I know Andy and I are going to Indianapolis the first week of October to meet with 14 other states that are working in this space and getting some great coordination and networking to figure out what other states who are a little bit further along are doing and getting feedback on that to make sure that we are, you know, nationally best in class and what decisions we're making to move forward. But I would expect us by spring to have all of those things in a row and be able to provide

[04:45:02] presentations for the board. I'm sure you're thinking of this already, but one of the things we are leading the nation on is the work we're doing with the fast forward program that Sheldon is administering. And that list may be more restrictive, maybe narrower than the list you ultimately want, but it's a pretty good list as a starting point, right? Those are credentials that industry has recognized as being immediate needs. And it's a well-vetted list that's tied to state funding for credentialing through the community colleges uh that's that data piece is just taking

[04:45:39] all this and putting together and that's a perfect example that's a that's a list that would easily start everything on their list ought to be on our list our list might want to be broader than that but it's hard to imagine anything on the fast forward list that has been well vetted across industry sectors might be a good starting place thank you final comment here for you is um in in the slide where the overview of the presentation is you have the four uh essentially indicators there and just wondering how we can see perhaps a civic readiness indicator here um because i do

[04:46:18] believe strongly that that is a really essential piece of life as an american citizen um and so i would absolutely encourage us to look at adding civic readiness to this as well and i'd be remiss as a former civics and government teacher if i did not insert that into this conversation it is in the language that's why there's three seats but i language i want to see it pulled out well and i also don't know whether in our current indicator whether there are any markers that connect to it other you know work-based learning but and there are um states like massachusetts

[04:46:57] do a civic readiness test that is administered in high school to students and they have an entire broad-based plan over how they administer those tests and it's it's pretty it's pretty extensive and a really good program so that's great yeah other ideas two states have their kids take the naturalization test which is a great idea just maybe one other thought too andy i think on our lab schools committee there a lot of the applications coming in are joint ventures with the community colleges and the districts and it might just be another conduit for us to

[04:47:35] to look at for some of the potential dual enrollment models and other things that we might be looking for i could spend another hour talking about that probably more than i have already yes thank you dr armstrong thank you i'm happy to have you on board thanks okay so it looks like dr salari is with us. Dr. Solari, can you hear us? I can. Oh, hey, there you are. I can hear you and see you.

[04:48:07] Welcome. Great. Thank you. We are ready for you. Okay. I just want to make sure you can see my PowerPoint once it pops up. While you're doing that, Dr. Solari, I asked Dr. Solari to come because last month you talked a lot about readiness and elementary and literacy measures and wanted to have Dr. Solari, who is really leading the national charge on creating a formative measure and using that in Virginia over the next year or so. And I wanted her to give an update on

[04:48:43] what that is, what the intent is to make sure you had informed conversation for tomorrow's discussion around elementary readiness. So thank you very much. Dr. Slar is extremely busy, so I appreciate her zooming in and talking to us today. Yeah, thank you so much for having me. And I apologize for not being able to be there in person. I'm actually out of Virginia today, outside of Virginia today. Can you can see the slides? Yes, yes. Okay. So I'm just going to do a hopefully very brief here background on where we've been on literacy screen in Virginia and provide some information to everyone around where we're going with the revision of the new literacy screener.

[04:49:23] So most folks know that in Virginia, we have been screening kids since last century. I like to say that because it seems like a long time ago. It was 1997. We actually, Virginia actually led the country in this space. There has been no other state or across the country that has screened kids continuously with a similar measure across all school divisions for so long. And there's a lot of strengths in having a system that, you know, that provides the similar literacy data in the k-3 space most folks in education also know that in most states in most cases we don't start

[04:50:00] assessing kids until third grade and for in literacy that is often far too late to detect early literacy difficulties and to intervene early and we know that early intervention is really very critically important in literacy so um while we've had this amazing screening system we've had a screening system that was way ahead of its time it also had never been revised since the early 2000s and so when i arrived at uva understanding that uva ran the literacy screening system for the state it was very clear to me at that time even before i came to virginia already knowing the powell system that it needed to be updated it needed to be updated to ensure that it was aligned

[04:50:40] with the most current evidence space so our office has been involved in that process over the last two-plus years in close collaboration with many divisions in the Department of Education, and also in close collaboration with our VKRP and Pre-K partners in this space.

[04:50:58] We have developed a new screener. That's the good news. That's the short story here. I want to talk a little bit about the purpose of a screener. When we think about a screener, we're thinking about an early warning system for risk. Screening of really critical early literacy concepts allows us to know which kids are at risk for reading and writing failure and which kids may be at risk for reading comprehension failure down the road so it allows educators to know which kids might need a little bit more dosage or a little bit more attention in these early literacy skills and we know that pairing evidence-based classroom instruction

[04:51:35] to supplemental instruction that you know for kids who might need more is the most effective approach to preventing later reading difficulties you've heard me talk about the literacy act you've heard everyone talk about the lizard literacy act um i just want to just want to you know sort of put this in the context of literacy act i think it's really important to show that this work goes hand in hand with everything else happening around literacy in virginia one of the goals of literacy act is to align curricula screening and intervention methods so this piece up here in the corner is what we're talking about ensuring that we are collecting the right data from kids early in the early grades so that it can guide instructional critical instructional

[04:52:15] decisions around literacy screen is just one part of a comprehensive system of assessment and so when we the screening measure that we're talking about which is the new version we'll call we will be called the virginia language and literacy screening system that will be replacing the name of pals which i think has shocked some folks that we're changing the name but we are is really a measure that has been developed as a screener it's not an outcome measure it's not something it's not a cumulative outcome measure like an sol or a napa assessment it is a screening

[04:52:51] measure to detect at this time where is this key literacy and what do they need from an instructional lens to ensure that they are on track for later success in reading so we know that screening tools need to be evidence-based when i talk about revisions one big thing here is we got to make sure that we are up to date our school needs to be up to date with the current reading science or science of reading or science science legally based reading research needs to be valid it needs to be sensitive there's a train outside sorry if you didn't hear that it needs to be sensitive to to um detecting the kids who are at risk so that we can make um instructional decisions and it needs

[04:53:28] to be efficient so this is not something that should take teachers a ton of time we don't want to detract from teaching time we want to make sure that it's an efficient tool that teachers can use in a feasible way with all students in the classroom, especially when we're talking about universal screening in those really early grades. So why update the literacy screener? I talked about this a little bit. I'm not going to spend a ton of time here, but we know that reading comprehension is the product of decoding and language comprehension. And what I mean by that is that kids have to know how to read words efficiently and effectively, and they also have to develop really critical language comprehension skills. And those two things together predict

[04:54:06] reading comprehension over time so what is cool about that is this is more complicated i'm not going to spend much time here is that we know that there are some component skills under decoding and

language comprehension the two broad skills that are really important for reading comprehension over time and so when you know that there are early developing skills that are related to decoding and language comprehension what that does it provides you a couple of things um a couple of things one it tells you which early literacy source should you be measuring to make sure you are creating a screener that is predictive of later reading comprehension outcomes

[04:54:44] and it also gives teachers really clear teaching targets and the screener should drive those teaching targets in early grades so the original pal screener only collected data on the decoding side of the equation so when we're talking about bringing this up to the most current evidence base the new screener will cover all of these components. So really very important to know that it is an expansion of the skills that we have been collecting in PALS and also an update to make sure that that decoding piece is aligned to the most current science as well. So how we're

[04:55:21] collecting the data around decoding is aligned to the most current science. So just so you are aware, we have been tasked with developing both an English and Spanish version of the screener. the Spanish version is not a translation it is its own screener based in how language and literacy develops in Spanish we had also been tasked with bringing the screener down to lower grade levels and to provide it to all publicly funded pre-k classrooms so we created a version for a new version for three and four year olds for children that are served in publicly funded pre-k and then

[04:56:01] also a version for kindergarten first second and third grade um the pre-k version actually launched last small for fall of 2022 so we are now actively analyzing all the data that came in yes last year to make sure that the screener is functioning in the way that we that it was supposed to critically important we do not want teachers spending time collecting data that they don't need to so if there's certain subtests that aren't adding to this sort of predictive equation or that aren't providing is not providing extra information we will pull sub tests we actually already have done that um so i think it's important for the board to understand that this is an evolving

[04:56:38] process and healthy screening systems are checked in on often um the data are run often to make sure that they are functioning in the way that they ought to be um so these are the different assessments that we are doing to cover both that the coding and language comprehension side of the equation or revision names where we were tasked with bringing it down to pre-k three-year-olds all the way up through grade three, make it more comprehensive, making sure we're collecting all the information we should be collecting, and making it more use instructionally relevant. So

[04:57:16] the teacher spends time collecting data. They should be able to use that data to guide their instruction. We do not want teachers collecting data to simply just collect the data and put it to this side so the ultimate goal was this is a really important lever when we think about the literacy act to ensure that teachers have the data necessary to drive instruction to improve outcomes for kids across virginia so our screener revision timeline has been multiple years we actually started developing items for the new screener well before 2021 we were you know we kind of internally tasked ourselves with that knowing that the pal system needed to be updated we officially

[04:57:55] launched the pilot of that in 2021 from pre-k to grade three in both english and spanish and we've been collecting data every school year since again pre-k launched 2022 and we are in the middle here in our process so we currently fall 2023 re we launched the new screening system the new england

screening system in 17 divisions across the commonwealth and it is currently being used in those divisions in lieu of the old legacy system pals so divisions that opted in to use the new

[04:58:29] system no longer are collecting pals data and the fall of 2024 is the full launch for the entire commonwealth so next year all 131 divisions will be on the new system in english and in spanish will follow um the next academic the next year we are continuing to refine the spanish and collect data in that space um so like i said these are the 17 divisions that are currently using the new screener we tried really hard to get um divisions from all over virginia to make sure we had regional representation um and divisions chose if they wanted to use a k2 or k3 and the

[04:59:08] divisions that are only using the k2 are our own data collectors from uva are going in to collect the data in third grade for this year because we want to continue to develop that sample size to ensure that the screeners function as it ought to be. We're also continuing to pilot the Spanish version this year to build our overall sample size. We've had to strategically recruit divisions who have higher populations of Spanish-speaking students. I also just pause to say that this work, it would not be possible without our division partners. And they have been incredibly generous with their time and

[04:59:43] their space to allow us to come in and collect the data. So we're in 17 divisions with the new screener and all the rest are still on the legacy pal system so this is a little bit of a different year for virginia with some divisions using the new screen and some using the legacy system and we're trying to provide as much opportunities as possible for the field to better understand how it's working for teachers and reading specialists and administrators we have also of course provided training um you know through our in our new system all teachers who are using the screener

[05:00:16] are certified in its use and then also we have you know part of this is the why um why do we need a new screener we have been using pals forever why do we need to change what we're doing and so part of what we have been working hard on is the messaging around that um we need more comprehensive information about kids and also messaging to our teachers and our administrators and our reading specialists that like you should expect your screening system to be updated it's not something that should sort of just be developed once and there's not many updates later a healthy screening system is going to have revisions over time and that's and that's okay

[05:00:57] um so this is a little bit about our our um our support so we um we have always had a very robust uh hotline support for the pals legacy system that continues with the about with the new system with the with the new screener um our staff are around all the time and you know our we like to say the hotline is on fire it has been on fire the last few weeks as you can imagine um there are many many questions for these 17 divisions and we welcome that and we're trying to help them through this process of change i mean change changing the way in which you're assessing kids

[05:01:33] if you've been doing it the same way for 10 or 15 years can can be difficult um so we offer both remote and in-person training and then all day long hotline supported for people to call in and to problem shoot with us really quickly the new system is we'll have new and improved data reports this is really really critical to make sure that the system drives instructional change for teachers and they know what to do with the data so there's teacher level reports there's student level reports there's class summaries and there's division level reports that folks will have access to. The literacy screener provides both bands of risk and instructional indicators. And what we mean

[05:02:08] by that is we are a child, after they take all the assessments, they get put into a group of low risk, moderate risk, or high risk. The kids who are high risk are also qualified for EIRI dollars, as has always been the case based on the state level screener for PALS. So if you're in that group who's the most high risk, you qualify for that EIRI designation and 2.5 hours of supplemental instruction um every week and we have a moderate risk and low risk and we thought it was really important to message to teachers that just because you are not in that high risk if you're

[05:02:45] even in the moderate risk group um you are still potentially at risk for reading difficulties and we need to be paying attention to those kids when we look at the data longitudinally from the pals data the kids who are scoring just above that benchmark and a little bit higher those kids are still at risk for reading difficulties and reading comprehension issues in the long run.

[05:03:06] So instead of this sort of like cut it off, you're at risk versus not, we're messaging this differently now to teachers around low, moderate, high and providing teachers with information about how to provide instruction for kids who are at high and moderate risk and what kind of dosage they need and what kind of instruction. The other thing it does is that at each sub test level, so we test letter sounds we test reading we test um spelling if a child is at a certain level the system will tell the teacher at the student level that that particular area is an instruction needs

[05:03:43] more instruction so this is really really important for driving that instructional piece so if i have a group of seven kids in my class let's say who need more letter sounds the system is little sound instruction the system is going to tell the teachers who those kids are so they can group them for instruction that goes through across all the different subtests so again timeline for full implementation i already talked about um and we are we are working rapidly to make it there for fall of 2024 for full implementation of the english screener in all 131 divisions k-3 pre-k

[05:04:22] has already been launched so we'll also new systems there as well i'm myself and i'm happy to answer questions um i have a question dr salari um so of course i can imagine this is already happening but in uh just as um an opportunity to reiterate that this is happening um looking at those instructional indicators uh on i guess it's slide 27 i love being able to have that visual

[05:04:57] piece but i also want to talk about um how you all are already conducting professional development very deeply aligned with these specific indicators and how teachers are taking those things and using them to specifically target um their instructional practices so if you could yeah that yeah it's a great question so everything that we are doing around the screener is all also making it into the all the professional development work for being specialists and teachers as a part of the virginia literacy act professional development so the way in which we are will be meeting and

[05:05:36] are currently meeting sort of uh getting to all teachers around how you use the screener um is through that that's the pathway so it's through the professional development that is currently being done through the virginia literacy act we also have you know publicly available and resources sort of behind the scenes within the new system the other thing i didn't talk about is that the entirety of the system is now on a new platform so while we were developing content we also developed entirely new a tech platform for this and within that system um if kids have um instructional need

[05:06:14] they can they are linked to publicly available what we call instructional protocols and anyone can go and find those those are on our website so you can pull down um let's say you need more instruction in phonics for example you can go to our website and you can take maybe the five or six kids

who need more help in finance and you can pull instructional protocols from our website to do more intensive instruction in that particular space and that's true across letter knowledge is true for phonological awareness for phoneme awareness for decoding for phonics so those are available the protocols are there the other thing that's there is we have created video

[05:06:53] exemplars of the implementation of this type of instruction what does it look like to make sure folks know how it is direct is explicit it provides opportunities many opportunities for children to respond in it and you have to be providing adequate scaffolding so we put out videos and all to sort of show this so teachers can go and see what it's supposed to look like and in front of them they actually have the protocols, or if you want to call them lesson plans, they're protocols so they can then take it and implement it in the context of their own classroom.

[05:07:23] Thank you. Anyone else have a question for Dr. Solari around this? Ms. Holtan? Thank you, Dr. Solari. This is amazing work, and we're really much blessed to have you leading it. Thank you. Can you help me remember, there was a time when PALS was used in almost all divisions, but there were one or two significant divisions that we must have at that point allowed them to opt to use an additional, an alternative screener, and they did. And it was also, there was also a

[05:07:58] time when it was only mandated for kindergarten. Is it now either because of the Literacy Act or otherwise, is it now mandated statewide or pre-K all the way through three, either PALS or VALS? Yeah, so currently the only division, so Fairfax is using a combination of things.

[05:08:20] In kindergarten, they currently use PALS. They actually were not using PALS, and they came back to the PALS screener last year. And this is related to, you know, making sure that we are in sync with the VKRP system, which, you know, goes pre-K to K.

[05:08:36] We are currently working with Fairfax to pilot the new screener. And it is my understanding that they have interest in adopting the new screener once it is available. And at that point, every single division would be using the same screener.

[05:08:52] But that's not because of a mandate. It's because you've been persuasive rather than local divisions have all opted in, except for Fairfax. And you're hopeful that they will be opting in. But the Literacy Act apparently doesn't mandate it.

[05:09:10] Hopefully they will opt back in because they give us an apples to apples comparison. Right. That's what you do. The value of having a universal screener is huge, and so that's something I'd be interested in hearing if it's if it's not already part of VLA that it's mandated.

[05:09:28] That might be something we want to think about whether we have the authority to address or whether we want to make some recommendations to our friends in the legislature. And then I guess my second question would relate to that. If and when it's universal, is this, well, maybe regardless of that, is SAS already using the PAL scores as part of their VVAS growth measure?

[05:09:54] And this may be for Dr. Koons or somebody else she's pointing at, rather than you. Are they already using PALS and will roll over to VALS? And if not, is that a possibility? Is that an appropriate use of it? And just for your sake, Dr. Solari, Lisa is waving at somebody to help us.

[05:10:14] Dr. Meyers. Yeah, they can speak to that. I can also develop it if Dr. Meyers wants to get us totally fine. That's great. Hi, Dr. Solari. How are you? Good afternoon. We actually worked very closely with

Emily when we were looking at PALS data.

[05:10:33] And it was determined in Vivos that PALS data was really not, was never created or really shouldn't be used for projecting growth with students. There wasn't, we just didn't feel that there was, and we used a lot of technical guidance and she could tell you a little bit more of the reason why on the test.

[05:10:55] But we spent an entire afternoon in this room and decided that it would not be appropriate to use that in projections for growth. we did um use it we they did take sas has pals data just as historical data so that it it could be seen in a report but it's not being used for projections for growth and just really briefly the original pal screener was never developed to measure growth over time is that's something you have to do when you start to develop a screener it was meant to be a snapshot at that particular

[05:11:33] time with a kid and not to be used as a growth measure over time but even separately from whether it serves as a growth measure it's also not a useful baseline i mean the way sas described the vivas measure to us they use multiple different data points as a baseline that they that they then determine growth from but not appropriate for for that use either in other words yeah and i think

[05:12:01] Dr. Solari can speak to the PALS much better than I can, but I also know that the work that they've been doing on her team will allow for a much more longitudinal look at this and to be able to use it in the future. But it was never built, as she said, to be able to use the year-over-year growth like that, like you could with an SOL.

[05:12:22] And therefore also not appropriate for us to look to as an accountability indicator. Is that right? yeah so it was not the measure was not developed for that use and so we do what you we do not know if it's it would be vial valid and reliable to be used for that um because it was not ever developed with that in mind okay thank you any other i mean the only other thing there is it's not an outcome measure right so that's important thing to stress here it is a measure to to sort of predict

[05:13:02] performance over time and provide really really relevant instructional information for teachers that's very specific and more specific than an slo assessment that is more of an outcome broad based measure these are very specific skills that we know predict over time but really used for instructional purposes thank you dr northern okay so i was at uva 20 some years ago used to work in in the PALS office back in the day with a couple friends of mine. So glad that this is being

[05:13:39] reinvented. It's long overdue in terms of the age of PALS and what it was created to do versus what we need it to do. So kudos to you guys for taking this to us to the next generation of identifying reading difficulties because in my opinion PALS couldn't get us there. It was great for the purpose it was intended for 20 some years ago, but it's just not up for the task today. So just congratulations on all this hard work that you've put into taking us into the, you know, 2023 school year and beyond. Thank you. And the work would not be possible without our partners

[05:14:19] in the department. So thank you to them as well. All right. Thank you, Dr. Solari. Unless Dr. Cairns might have something for you. I just wanted to say that this year, you know, we're going to to get ready and talk about the grade 3-8 data and some of the results this year, but tools like this and tools like what Dr. Solari has launched in the VLA work and in partnership with DOE as we get ready for the Virginia Literacy Act, this is very important for us to be talking about, very important for us to be thinking about, because we know that tools like this that drive foundational instruction and first-time instruction for children are

[05:14:58] game changers and it's the most important thing we can be doing and i'm really incredibly proud to work with dr solari because there's nothing else like this in the nation that is this high quality and this cutting edge so really excited to be able to really help our school divisions vision how to use this use this well train our reading specialists and our teachers but also put materials in front of our teachers that allow them to be able to execute really strong instruction so this is one piece of the puzzle. We'll continue to bring more pieces of the VLA puzzle over the next several months because as a board, I'm just, I've given a call to action to many people

[05:15:34] across the state. This is a very important space that we need to lean in on and making sure everybody reads VA and all of our children are on track. And I really want to say thank you to Emily for leading this early grades level kind of frontline early warning system for our educators and our students so thank you thank you happy to share and happy to you know check back in whenever folks would like me to thank you dr salari we appreciate your participation today thank you okay does anyone

[05:16:09] need a break at the moment yes okay can we have a five minute break please come back to order i

[05:26:29] would like to call on i guess it's dr siebert who's going to provide us our 585 update on a a House Bill 585 workgroup update and first I would just like to thank the board members that have been participating in that workgroup prior to Dr. Northern's appointment to the board. She was a part of that workgroup before she became a member of the board and so we were both Dr. Siebert and I were a part of that group with her and certainly are very

[05:27:04] happy now that she is a part of our board and um yes so and of course it complicated the last few meetings where we couldn't have all three of us involved so uh we we've divvied up my plan is to kind of run through the slides just create context then uh phone in friends uh for who have been involved in the process to elaborate and then as a discussion involves i think really dr coons who's also been very very involved in the 55 work group uh would be ideal to facilitate that in conjunction with the chair um i from a teaching point of view excellent transition from dr salari to this

[05:27:41] conversation because that concluded with dr salari and dr northern talking about things that it was created to do things that we no longer needed to do we need to do new things and it was just not up to the task that is where our commonwealth assessment system is right now it was created to do things that it did well times have changed and it is no longer up to the task so i'm I'm just going to back up and try a little bit of context. Virginia was a pioneer, a pioneer in accountability and assessment, assessment accountability.

[05:28:12] We were a pioneer. So our assessment system predates No Child Left Behind, and it had very good origins. And now those origins were to address problems at the time. And this is overly simplifying the problem. But one of the questions was, how do we make sure that algebra in all parts of the state is algebra?

[05:28:31] And so really, the SOL test came online as a test of minimum proficiency. Could you do the minimum amount of those content areas? Now, the other thing that had to happen in the early 90s as the assessments rolled out was they had to be done at scale, every child.

[05:28:50] And they had to be done, let's face it, affordably. How do you do something affordable at scale and still have some reliability and validity? Well, you end up with a fixed response assessment, 35, 40

items. And you use that same tool, fixed response assessment, 35, 40 items, whether you're talking about chemistry or algebra or reading or U.S. Virginia history.

[05:29:13] Now, we've heard, we've started keeping tally marks over the past year, so we really hear best in class a lot. We want to use best in class, not just Virginia versus other states, but in each content area. Let's respect, PALS respects that early literacy is different than comprehension and things later, the upper level of literacy, writing, whatnot.

[05:29:32] We need to respect that content areas are different. And the idea that a 35, 40 question fixed response test can do chemistry, as well as it can do reading, as well as it can do Virginia history and geometry, just we need to think about that. So not disparaging the system we have, we were a pioneer.

[05:29:51] But when you build something the first time, you start with some load-bearing walls. And we have some load-bearing walls in place in our assessment system that it is past time to look at. There's also thankfully been a lot of work done on this for a lot of years by different groups and different organizations and different committees, and so there's lots of good ideas there that were there to drive this.

[05:30:12] Now, House Bill 585 came out of the 22 General Assembly. It actually started as a bill to bring about some changes in our assessment system, and then a whole lot of work happened during the session to move that around. And what ended up happening was it became a work group, and that kind of slowed it down, but it just gave us this very, very thoughtful, very, very thoughtful approach.

[05:30:32] But it is indeed past time to modernize. So Virginia's assessments just, again, well-intentioned, well-designed, served the purpose, but currently we know as our bodies, policymakers, it's not meeting our needs. Well, I can tell you from the field, it's not necessarily meeting the needs there.

[05:30:48] So it is time to redo. So the assessment is a powerful system. As we start thinking about accountability measures and accountability approaches, everybody in the field is going to want to know, okay, but what's under the hood? And what's under the hood are the assessments. And so it's very important that we do those right and we do those well.

[05:31:07] So because it was a work group and it was a bill that had been around lots of places and it became a work group, it had lots of things to do. So kudos to the secretary's office, the state superintendent, her team, the group of watershed advisors who facilitated her to this group of cats. we had a lot of things that we needed to work on and look at and so that kind of led to how do you structure these meetings so our first meeting was in March and it was just kind of like okay here's this group a diverse group of people different expertise different perspectives let's talk about what we're doing now how we're doing it some of the challenges we moved into meeting two in April and we we started looking at some best practices we looked at things from Massachusetts and

[05:31:47] Louisiana and Texas and different places to really begin looking at different things then we came back to think about our system compared to what we've seen what could work on it then we began working on some draft recommendations and so where we are now is we're considering final recommendations really trying to identify the legislative relief that might be needed what would be legislative what would be regulatory what can we do ourselves versus what can the general assembly do and again there's there's going to be tendrils there because the things that have been happened over the past 25 years legislatively that that to make changes that we'll have to be mindful of but you see here the report report due to the general assembly by november 1st

[05:32:24] and um and really i think the conclusion here will be that the next steps we really are going to need is we're going to need to know we need a bill that does this or does that to help us with the elbow room that we need and i think modernizing assessment system can be a bipartisan bicameral effort uh that we can we can help a lot of our friends in the general assembly get get behind so looking at the recommendations um we talked a lot about rigorous standards and every time i could hear our dear colleague uh board member rotherham say rigors like beauties in the eye of the beholder you know how are you going to do this so so we but but we knew that we had to talk about standards

[05:33:02] and in that in that regard uh we're on a journey looking at our standards the other nice thing virginia has is we have this recurring timeline of assessing our standards and we'll get here on the next slide just a minute that's very helpful very handy and can also be a tool for us moving forward with how we look at assessments um the idea that we we weren't you know challenging items um again originally because our system predated things maybe it's now that we time look at that our passing our cut scores our scores our thresholds be aligned if we're going in line with nate let's talk about proficient versus basic versus below basic um and let's really think about those things because our original scores passing that minimum um and minimum in the 1990s

[05:33:39] is not what proficient is in 2023 so there's some legacy pieces of the system that we need to tie together here uh really the idea of coherence in the system and then how can we you know kind of future proof it and and become better for future plans the if you look at number four their improved system lots and lots of work has gone and lots of conversations throughout the meetings about measuring student growth and we're appreciative of what uh vivos can do for us but the the the recurring theme there for for a ensuring student growth these are the desires for not just

[05:34:14] policy makers not just school leaders but for moms and dads and children themselves to have direct authentic measures of an individual child's growth um and and not not calculate over time but just you know uh think think about the old measurement chart growth chart when you went up to took your children to got their height you got their weight you can see where they were see where they've been um and you can see where they were based on the the the standard deviations about their population their age that's very very helpful which again brings us to uh this this process right here so

[05:34:48] sorry this is the slide that i'm speaking to with 4a and the nice thing we have is if we can start linking our modernization of our assessments going forward in conjunction with the content area they're associated with that will be a way to respect the content area so in the future as we look at you know math standards that process can involve what are the best ways to measure these standards what are the best tools uh rather than using one kind of adjustable wrench for all the content areas what can we really do to make make these the overall system better so again it is

[05:35:25] it is time for modernization uh lots of thought and good efforts here but what teasing out what is a regulatory thing that the board can do versus what are things that are already in code that we need a general assembly to do and then of course always reconciling that fact that although these things should reside with our body general assembly can do things faster sometimes so that's uh some of the the harsh realities there but with that i would like to uh invite uh dr northern and and president creasy to elaborate and then um president coons to help dig me out the hole i may have dug

[05:36:08] i can go back to whatever slide you want to go to well we're on uh you haven't you're taking a pause here right before we go into some of these um recommendations is that is that we're doing or we

just did we just went through those quickly right yeah i i was setting the stage now you can you all can perform um i mean i thought it was a very smooth functioning group i mean personally i still have to submit my feedback on the you know the semi-final draft um i was you know i'm not real sure how far the group was supposed to get to be honest you know in the grain size of the recommendations were we kind of looking like these are kind of like you know aspirational they're

[05:36:48] good guideposts and i certainly think they make sense uh but but i'm still you know i'm not i'm not clear um whether we actually met the met the intent of the charge we were given in terms of the specificity of the recommendations maybe we did maybe we didn't um but i think that these five um are fantastic um in terms of what we need to do um if if maybe lacking a little bit bit of specificity. I think I'd have to, excuse me, I think I'd have to agree with the lacking

[05:37:23] in specificity. And that could have simply been a result of so many different voices in the room to provide a more generalized direction for this project. But I do feel strongly that we were given some really great opportunities to evaluate different states and how they are assessing students in similar, for similar purposes. And so, you know, those of us who've kind of been

[05:38:01] stuck in the SOL box for so long are used to a certain means by which our students are going to have that end of course assessment conducted, presented to them. All of those things were things that we talked about, you know, the lockdown, for lack of a better term, of our school buildings during those testing times. And, you know, are those particular practices effective in gaining from our students exactly what their achievement levels are? All of those

[05:38:37] kinds of discussions occur during these meetings. And what I really am most looking forward to is number five there. And that is that innovative design of more specifically, just the test questions and looking to how we are designing those test questions in each discipline. So that it is a different way that we are addressing the different contents instead of saying everybody is

[05:39:13] have is being assessed for every single core content this way we did do a lot of discussion around how can we really differentiate that assessment opportunity here so that that i love i love and hate the word innovation because i think it's often overused but i really do think that at this point that's kind of the best way to describe really the direction that we were going in with um the opportunities that are very abundant for us to make some not only significant changes but also making them really positive changes to truly

[05:39:52] measure best how students are achieving so dr coons i think it would be important to add you have created really strong guideposts in this draft in these recommendations those are really strong guideposts what we have to do now is we have to take that to our TAC our technical advisory commission and really sit down with our technical advisory commission who are national independent experts on actually designing and say to them based on these recommendations based on what you know about our assessment what is the actual grain size of how to build an assessment and use now

[05:40:29] their expertise to take all of these stakeholders what you vision as amber as you said aspirationally what needs to be in there and tell us then this is what your assessment needs and this is what your rfp then would need off of those technical assessments so i think these guideposts are very helpful i think being part of those conversations part of the anecdotal work really helps set the forth to say to the technical advisory committee this is what virginia wants in their modernized assessment system

this is what they want to be best in class to be front to be innovative and to get back in that game help us think about what are the very technical things that then have to

[05:41:08] happen to put those guardrails in place the group said things like we need prioritize retake we need this we need some of these and i think the best minds are the people who design this technically and advise states across the country and can then say this is what you would need in an rfp to make that happen so i think this is a tremendous amount of work and a tremendous amount of voice and i've not seen this in my other opportunities so i'm really excited to represent the voice represent the level of report and then take it to that independent third-party technical advisory committee and say this is the vision that our our 585 work group wants for virginia

[05:41:47] how do we build an rfp that really represents that expertise i think some things you politely kind of pointed out those of us are working groups like this in the past it we quote from a dear friend i love is we should never confuse activity for accomplishment and i i think there's been a whole lot of of activity and great thought but to get this across the finish line i guess as superintendent said the rfp process is there but also um you know we really with the general assembly is going to be here in no time at all we really need to think about what our legislative

[05:42:23] asks that would either remove some barriers or create some opportunities for us because right So right now some of the, in reading them, I can think of some of these that we can all agree on. This is good stuff. I like apple pie. But if we want to talk more about pie, probably do you think about your crust fillings and who makes it and all those kinds of things with the ingredients are. So I do think that some specificity and some legislative action is very important. To be clear, there have also been innovations in the system we have. We've learned last year about how reading and writing are now integrated. You know, there's some cool stuff happening in areas, but this is a time for a comprehensive

[05:42:59] So one other thing that I would like to just bring up is that, of course, we have we have a system right now in place that we are fiscally used to.

[05:43:14] And it is as we look to this this idea of innovative assessment design and the opportunity to potentially differentiate a lot of those assessment opportunities.

[05:43:31] disabilities discipline to discipline. I think it's really important that we have to keep in mind that this is going to cost you know this is this is going to be something that we're going to have to certainly invest in with the understanding that the investment that we make is going to yield us better information better outcomes for students and so as we focus on the best outcomes for our students i think this is just yet another step that we have to take towards that end miss holton so i i guess this is partly a comment and partly a question

[05:44:10] this looks like i think really strong work i don't think you all just met because i agree with dr kunz you've given some guideposts i do think that kind of my so my historian role um i would just want to emphasize how in many ways how burdensome our current system is so while there may be costs with a new system our current system has a lot of cost too because we are making it up by ourselves every year or every cycle we do our own tests and if we aren't taking advantage of the economies of

[05:44:45] scale of some of these national assessment systems that's got to be uh it's just very burdensome watching the uh the work the department does with our testing partner build testing items ourselves and and so maybe we're not ready to go maybe it wouldn't make sense for our virginia sols which are ours

exclusively to to go to a national test but maybe i'm hearing we might be able to purchase test items for some of our content that is aligned with the national tests especially in the basic

[05:45:22] topics like numeracy and literacy. And then we might not have to, when we're looking at how to implement new tests for the math standards, we might not have to be field testing our own items because somebody nationally has already field tested them. It's just a huge burdensome system what we're doing now. And I think one of the, and it creates confusion. So one of the things that we we have some differences of opinion on is, have we, did we cut back scores? Did we reduce rigor

[05:45:55] a few years ago here in Virginia? Well, the same facts can be characterized in different ways. But how I would characterize our system is we create new standards every seven years in every content area. And they're not completely new, like our math standards we just adopted. Largely, a lot of carries over from old standards but we create new content we move things around we add new material and then the department goes and works with our testing provider to create a new a whole new test

[05:46:30] and sometimes the test is many items longer than it was before and sometimes it's many items shorter than it was before but once they create the test items then it goes through a complicated process with an articulation committee and i can't remember what the second committee is called and then you know they each score teachers confer and score and mr rotherham's wisely pointed out that maybe we don't want just k-12 teachers in that room but currently i think it's mostly or all exclusively k-12 teachers scoring each test question as to whether they think a

[05:47:04] student on the cusp should be able to pass that test answer that question accurately they score each individual item and then it's summed up in the through a complicated process and comes to us with recommendations from the superintendent but it's a whole new test to match a whole new standard each seven years in each content area and you know the cut scores might be lower because there were fewer questions asked you know your cut score if you're only going to ask 50 questions when you ask 75 before then the number's going to be lower there was one occasion when the board

[05:47:40] went with the articulation committee recommendations instead of the superintendents recommendations in literacy and they were lower than the superintendents recommendations in this 2021 we never went under the superintendents and the committee's recommendations with respect to the numeracy tests so it it's again it's a complex system and it's not at all necessarily the best system but i guess my real point here is it's a cumbersome system where we're having to do it all ourselves every time now if we were to take advantage of some of the national uh resources

[05:48:16] we'd still have to determine our own cut scores we'd still have to make plenty of decisions we'd have to maybe create some of our own test questions for materials that were in virginia sols that aren't in other materials and and i think frankly beyond math and english language arts we would we would absolutely need to continue to create our own tests because i don't think there's probably anything comparable but i just i guess my bringing all that long comment around to a question did you all look are there potentials economies of scale that we can be looking at as part of

[05:48:51] part of this rfp through the taking advantage of some of the work that's going on in the standardized tests in use nationally i think one of the things that the work group did is looked at our standards in virginia and compared our standards with standards in other states and looked at whether the standards were concrete and whether they were clear the content standards to build assessment items

right because our assessment items come from the concrete nature of our standards so i think there's a lot of conversation about how do you build good standards to build good assessment

[05:49:26] items and so when we looked at other states there were different levels of clarity and concreteness in our standards in comparison to other standards and lots of recommendations around clarity on the standards i think that would be a first step and is to making sure our standards are clear enough to even say whether or not national banks of items could be purchased to match our standards so i think the first step in the conversation around standards was an important one to set the tack to say are there items or are there assessment banks that would match these standards

[05:50:01] but we do have virginia standards and our assessments have to build off of those standards so we would have to look our current process allows us we have a we have a regular order and that would update that could definitely be part of an rfp opportunity to see if there are economies of scale along our standards but that would be an analysis i guess i'm sorry i didn't mean that but i what i was suggesting is on the assessment part on the standards part i'd be interested was the committee suggesting that we do something different than our seven-year cycle because we do have a system that enables us to regularly update and i can't frankly i can't

[05:50:38] imagine doing it any more often than seven years given i don't think they asked on frequency there's nothing on the recommendations on the deck that talks about frequency it's clarity so we have a process that enables us if we think they're not clear next time math comes up we can well i hope math is clear because we just did it that was one of the focus of the revisions was to to making sure in the mathematics, one of the things that when I came, I asked the team to make sure is that we were providing clear and concrete enough data in the standards so that we could build assessment items. And that is one thing out of the work group is to make sure that as we are

[05:51:14] revising standards, that there is clarity and concrete nature to the standards so that those can inform assessments. So I think that that was a definite focus. Tina presented on that last A couple of weeks ago, I love to say last month, but it was just 10 days ago that she presented and talked about the importance of clarity of standards to build assessment items.

[05:51:35] So we made sure that happened with math. So we think we have clear standards in math now. Literacy is up next year. So literacy is up this year. Well, 24, January 24. This academic year is up. So hopefully we'll be confident in the class. And some of it may be how much is in the standards versus how much is in the curriculum framework.

[05:51:52] And with math, you moved some, you consolidated essentially, we're skipping the curriculum framework on math, if I remember correctly. We did it all in one, right? We're not doing another round, I hope, on a curriculum framework in math. But anyway, all of that, that step, we should be done on, we should be in clear enough space on the standards in numeracy and literacy before this RFP happens.

[05:52:20] What I'm trying to say is that the 585 work group stated that we have to have clear standards. And so as we have clear standards, we'll be able to determine whether those standards have item banks across the nation to meet that economies of scale that you're recommending. Any more questions or comments on this item?

[05:52:46] Okay, we are ready for our item F, and that's Dr. Coons. I feel like I've been talking about this for weeks, and it has just been a few days since the data from the 22-23 SOLs was released.

[05:53:19] And so last Thursday, we announced some pretty stark and startling data. I wanted to have the opportunity to speak with the board, share with you where we are with our 22-23 SOLs, but also talk about the plan and the General Assembly's commitment of $418 million to address these concerns.

[05:53:40] So we're going to just dig in and start with the conversation around the data. And what we know happened in 22-23 is we saw a little bit of a different pattern. So as we all know, in 2018-19, we had really strong opportunity. And then in 2020-19-20, you'll see no testing, obviously, because we were in the pandemic. And during the pandemic, our kiddos were shuttered. They didn't have the opportunity to have the same learning experiences. And during 2021, we had a lot of students being quarantined, teachers being quarantined, and interesting things happen.

[05:54:13] So what we want to do is better understand the impacts of Covid-19, because as you saw over the summer, a lot of our national assessment providers were talking about this overarching decline. So NWAMAP, for example, gives an assessment across the country, and they probably have the largest pool of third through eighth grade assessment data.

[05:54:34] And they indicated in early July that they are seeing more persistent declines than expected in our upper grade students. And so that was the first flag. The second flag was when we started getting our data in our preliminary data as we were starting to get initial takes retakes those kinds of things.

[05:54:53] What we saw in our grade 3 8 data in 1819 you saw pretty strong data drop in 2021 obviously because of the pandemic in 2122 you saw a little pickup, but we saw that drop come back in 2023.

[05:55:10] and so what we wanted to understand is first cut scores changed in 18 19 and 2021 and that cut score change was dropping to minimum proficiency but it also was at the same exact time at covet in reading so it masked what actually happened with covid in virginia because the change in cut scores said it was easier to pass the test because it was moving to proficiency but it also masked those kiddos that 200 that 2018-19 peer group to the 2021 peer group so what shelly and katie and

[05:55:46] our team did is we looked at something called early proficiency that has been a long-standing category that they have used to calculate growth in virginia and early proficiency is that tan bar what practically that means is those kiddos scored one to three questions right that students who failed the rest ols did not score and as we all know if you're talking about proficiency emily just talked to us about low risk medium risk kiddos falling into categories focusing on our high risk kiddos but also not forgetting our medium risk kiddos it's a similar concept to

[05:56:22] what we're looking at in grade three through eight reading scores those tan kiddos are one to three questions ahead of kiddos who are non-proficient and if we actually look at this data you will see that over time and last year 30 of our kiddos were straight not proficient but another third of our students are at risk they are that medium risk category that emily salari talked about they are one to three questions away from not passing their third

[05:56:53] through eighth grade assessment so that means 38 of our students are solidly on track and 32 of of our kiddos are at risk and 30% did fully fail their proficiency. That means we are experiencing almost catastrophic issues with our 22-23 kiddos. The other thing we know about these scores is that if a student is at risk and in that tan band in third grade, they are more likely to be in the non-proficient in fourth grade and fall further and further behind. So we have to do

[05:57:28] something for our at-risk kiddos and our non-proficient kiddos, or we are going to be in a major situation when they get to high school, because these are the foundational years. They're the foundational years of literacy. As Emily talked a lot about, it's not just about being able to decode. It's that language comprehension, and we're really starting to see the impacts of COVID and those students who were in early reading development in grades three through eight, and we have to do something to intervene. So when we look at mathematics and we look at our mathematics scores, unfortunately, this is an even more startling space. When we look at 2018 pre-pandemic and we

[05:58:06] look at 2022-23, our kiddos are 15 percentage points behind their pre-pandemic peers when they're scoring. But if we look at that at-risk category, only one in three students are on track in grades three through eight math in Virginia. I'm going to go through student groups and I'm happy at the pause to take questions. What we're also looking at is when we look at our student group students. So when we look at our Black and our Hispanic student groups, they were behind before the pandemic. When we look at 2018-19, they were behind in their peers in reading. They were

[05:58:42] behind their peers in mathematics. But we are now just passing one in two students in our Black and Hispanic student groups. So the gap is actually widening in our post-pandemic days. In our post-pandemic work, we are seeing less and less students. And that's not even counting our at-risk categories in our Black and Hispanic students. That's just straight proficiency. When we look at our students in mathematics, our Black and Hispanic students are widening that gap even more. So while we have a major gap in mathematics with all grade three through eight students, we have a 20% inch point

[05:59:19] gap with our Black and Hispanic students and seeing dramatic gaps even more so in mathematics in grade three through eight. And then when we look at our economically disadvantaged, our English learners, and our students with disabilities, seven in 10 students last year did not pass the reading SOL if they were in the English language category. Those gaps are widening in our economically disadvantaged, and just less than four in 10 of our students with disabilities who test on our regular assessments are not meeting the expectations. That means that

[05:59:54] those students who were at risk before the pandemic are even more at risk and are struggling even more than all of our grade three through eight students. That is a drastic situation that we have to start thinking about our third through eighth graders. Our third through eighth graders are our future. And not only in reading, but in mathematics, we are seeing massive gaps in those students. And when we look at mathematics, it's even more dire with our gaps and with our students who are more fragile. We're not seeing that in high school. We're not seeing that same gap rate. We're not seeing that same foundational miss. If we think about our

[06:00:33] third, fourth, fifth graders, where they were four years ago, they were in that K-12 foundational space that Emily Solari talked so much about, the early warning system. And when we think about our sixth, seventh, and eighth graders, they were our third, fourth, fifth graders. They were putting those things together. They were figuring out that foundational element just past that developmental stage. Now those students have Swiss cheese gaps. And that makes sense, right? Because this student right here might have been there today this student might have been quarantined tomorrow their teacher might have been quarantined on day three and we had that in out in out sense for our students which meant they didn't have the same learning in those foundational years

[06:01:13] so now when you're looking at an early warning system that's so important every student has different gaps in learning and every student has different needs that is different than i would say 10 years ago when we implemented VTSS or interventions, you had much stronger patterns in development and gaps and in complex skills. We know that fractions are hard in mathematics.

[06:01:36] A lot of kids need support in fractions. That was kind of an easy way for us to do intervention based on those clusters. Today, it doesn't look like that in the data. Today, it looks like students with very individualized needs and individualized gaps. But in high school, we're seeing those students who miss more of their middle school experiences, recovering more quickly, being closer to pre-pandemic. This is statewide average. So I will say it's really important for our school divisions to continue to watch their high school students, to continue to see where those gaps might line. But if we look statewide, our third through eighth graders, I don't know quite what's

[06:02:13] happening with the slide, but we're just going to roll with it today. Our third through eighth graders in reading we are seeing one and two students either at risk and in that at risk category or not passing their third through eighth grade sols that that is a significant situation when we think about where our students are and what we need to be doing in third through eighth grade and making sure our students recover that learning and making sure our students are on track before they get to that high school space or before our students who are at risk continue to drop into that non-proficiency space in mathematics we're talking about an even more dire situation

[06:02:52] we're talking about two-thirds of our students either behind or not behind and not passing or at risk for not passing so as we think about our students in third through eighth grade that is a crisis moment for us as a state our school divisions have been working hard our teachers have been working hard they've been working hard every single day to recover our students our schools have been putting programs in place it is time for all of us to come in and all of us to support our schools and support our students in these categories and in these rates where we

[06:03:28] absolutely have to plug in with side by side with our teachers and support them so i wanted to bring that to you we talked about this a little bit with the governor last thursday but i'll pause there before we go to attendance because i know you have some questions thank you uh if you go back to slide four all right slide five i'll just uh this is just a informational question but and it may not you can answer it today but i'm hoping can we what was the tan number the tan number are those at-risk students that's a low proficient group but we

[06:04:03] don't have the data point for 2018-2019 that's correct because that's a change in the proficiency rates so those students would have been incorporated in just proficient so that at risk is that change in that drop and cut scores those students would have been included in the green bar in 2018-19 well because it was a different test in other words no it was a different proficiency um cut score the number of scores questions that needed to be correct in 2018-19 was higher than the new that was when the chess test we may characterize that differently but that was when the new standards and then the tests associated with the new standards the revised standards were adopted

[06:04:41] but you can't go back and then calculate that that equivalent of like you said it's an apple oranges comparison and what do you need on the next slide same question so that answer and then moving to slide i think it's slide 10 the high school piece sure i understand your characterization of the reading but i don't under the math it's better yeah it's better but it's not i mean it's still it's a pretty

significant drop you actually saw from 67 to 81 a massive increase that's a statistical anomaly to grow that much so the fact that they're holding that statistical anomaly

[06:05:20] is probably pretty strong and then the 81 on the reading is that just a typo there because that that would suggest that the reading didn't go down very much in high school correct we didn't have as much regression in high school and reading and then uh i think my i really um where we go from here question maybe later but how much of what we're doing in vla is going to address these challenges i think the point of vla is the best first foundational instruction which is incredibly important and it's an opportunity for us to give

[06:05:57] kiddos best first instruction it's geared to those earlier grades our third graders are fourth graders now our fourth graders are fifth graders vla doesn't get implemented until next year we have to do something right now for our kiddos who are moving through grade levels and this is an intervention that will add into the skills that our teachers are learning through vla thank you yep no problem if you go back to either the low proficient bar slides for just a moment um this this is where i just would help me to be an ambassador for the work if if i can

[06:06:35] better explain because again we most of us we're all programmed past past advance you know absolutely so so you know you said two to three questions but what yeah help me help me help others by helping myself first you know how low proficient was came about and and what are we did we use scale scores to get to that or we just use items you know what how did that happen there's a correlation chart that the team uses low proficient is how we calculate student growth today um dave and sas have talked about calculating growth future years using sas using those predictive measures the way in which virginia calculates growth right now is they take those

[06:07:13] four bands of official proficiency levels and they cut those into smaller categories of scale scores and then that translates to questions so if we look at the low proficient that's the bottom cut of the proficiency band that is one to three questions different than a non-proficient student and if we think about a test taker and we take think about a student who's at risk for being strong or not one to three questions is not a lot of questions for them to swing either way so i would think of that tan band as that at-risk category on a different day they may not be proficient or on a different day they may just barely be proficient and if we're thinking about

[06:07:50] catching up kiddos who are dropping over time and showing those gaps over time we have to think about that at-risk band as well as the non-proficient band so it's kind of related to the the vivos work in terms of looking at these bands so that that is helpful that this has been in the works for a while been in use for a while um that that that is helpful i i think i appreciate that yeah it is it is a long-term way we've calculated growth over time we just haven't talked about it

[06:08:19] And we wanted, as you talked earlier, getting better at using the tools we have until we have a modernized assessment system, we want to make sure we have an at-risk category and an early warning category to catch those students that don't seem to be improving but also seem to be dropping back down.

[06:08:35] And that's true when we look at the 22 data. We were like, okay, we're starting to recover. But seeing that significant drop in 23, we have to figure out why that's happening and what group of students we need to target to make sure that that doesn't become a big slide in 24.

[06:08:51] I also think this then echoes the 585 conversation we just had in terms of quality of assessments, because again, the answer to the field will be at every expedited retake, we see kids going up by seven, eight questions. And so there's individual pieces, again, the tools, having better tools to get to these conclusions is appreciated.

[06:09:16] I agree 100%, and we are doing the best with the tools we have to make sure we're flagging the kiddos who are at risk. so i totally agree i would say that the tools across the nation if we look at those other tools are also seeing similar drops in our middle grades so when we compare our tools to some of the other tools and what happened in july with some of those national assessments with national groups of students they are seeing that across across the country with other assessment tools as well mr rotherham okay can you go back to or i guess what do you want uh if you go back to four

[06:09:51] sorry backwards to four reading yeah i'm still confused and i'm not interested in sort of picking at old scabs i'm very interested in like where do we go but i don't understand this argument on cut scores my understanding was we did lower the cut score which makes me look at this data and think it would look even different but then i hear and and so i'm just i would could you just like pause because i think we have to level set on that and i think that's in part because like the conversation that goes on not in this room conversation that goes on like when these scores came out sure political conversation is a little bananas and i think it's in part because like there's not a lot

[06:10:26] of understanding about this yep so what is the question question is talk to me about the cut scores like i'm five years old and explain what happened um when and what the effect is it a different test or is it the same test the cut scores were lowered what would be the impact on this this data we're looking at i would need the assessment team to talk in very detailed level but we lowered the number of questions that had to be right in 20 not we past administration lowered the number of questions that had to be right to be proficient in 21 the year of post-covid so the

[06:11:02] first time we took a test post-covid we said you had to get less questions right to be proficient so is it reasonable then to assume that i'm looking at 2020 to 2021 and 2021 to 2022 on this chart and the data would actually be even more sobering had that change not made is that accurate yes that's what i'm trying to yes yeah may i just suggest and we're pulling an faq together right now shelly and katie and that team are pulling to your point clarity to make sure it's understandable something the superintendent's asked us yesterday in region one was to pull an faq to give very

[06:11:38] clear talking points to that effect yeah i think like i mean when i look at this for the fact that we came together in the budget and that there's money for this is fantastic i think some of us might want more and so forth but like what we have is a significant amount it's it's it we're going to talk about how we're going to spend it but i just don't think we can have like a healthy conversation around this commonwealth if we don't level a little bit and so we don't start to have some guardrails when people say things that are like just you know way out of bounds factually everyone's entitled to their own opinion but not to their own facts sure that we have some ways

[06:12:14] people can say because otherwise this is just like you know it really is like people say the moon's made of green cheese people say it's made of rock and you know the media writes that the debate over the lunar surface you know goes on whatever be resolved and that is at this moment just given how serious the state is that is like an enormous disservice to the kids and the educators frankly of this commonwealth well i think it's a two-part thing it's getting the faqs out so that the entire community has

those facts and clarity but it's also making sure that we are going and sitting down with superintendents and talking through this because this is a localized situation right each superintendent is going to read their data each ddot each instructional team and so we

[06:12:52] started that with region two and region one and we'll talk to every single superintendent team every instructional team to start helping us figure out what that means for each school division because it does look different in school divisions and they do have to think about what their data looks like what they're already doing what they need to do and that's a localized kind of conversation so absolutely ansel if i may yeah i i do think i actually think being forward looking is the most constructive thing to do uh because i think we all agree that these gaps are unacceptable

[06:13:27] and we've got to do something to raise up our most disadvantaged students and we also all agree that the overall learning loss for everybody is unacceptable and we've got to do something to address it i will say that i do think dr loving rider can walk us through at some point i think it would probably be useful to have her walk us through in some detail the process we have used in the past for setting cut scores because if we're gonna what i'm hearing there may be interest in this from this board and from the department in changing that cut score setting process and

[06:14:02] so people ought to understand what it is and what it was and i think a present presentation from her I was here. And so I do have factual knowledge of what happened, but she can explain it better. What happened in what our process has been and what happened in that process in 2018, 2019 after it was part of the regular schedule of the last time the math standards were updated and the last time the English language standards were updated.

[06:14:33] and then the cut scores came before us to be addressed. That's the point at which whatever happened happened and that people are characterizing it differently. But hearing from Dr. Levingrouter at some point about how that process works to the extent we need to, I wouldn't say we should go back and try to resolve and try to get unity on our characterization of those facts because it's not a productive use of our time.

[06:14:58] I'm going to characterize it differently from how Dr. Coombs characterizes it. I suspect no matter how long we talk about it, but the understanding that process may help inform, are we going to, when we say we're going to set cut scores to align with NAEP proficient, well, right now they're, that's, you know, the NAEP proficiency or basic numbers aren't even part of the process when the cut scores are set. Neither we nor the committees have that information in front of them. So do we want to change that process to have that information injected into

[06:15:34] it? And if so, how, and with what weight? So understanding the current process as a foundation for making revisions, I think, is productive. Yeah, well, I mean, I don't disagree with much. I do think the policy history matters, and I think it would be useful because it helps us understand what we're looking at. And going forward, I think the first part of what you said as the employee, this is a five alarm blaze. And I regret to say that is not like a universal sentiment. Well, I think it's been a five alarm blaze for decades. No, and thank you. Thank you for that. That is not a universal sentiment. And I think that is part of the problem that we have.

[06:16:11] And yes, it varies division by division. We certainly don't want to send a message that there's a five alarm blaze everywhere and unnecessarily alarmed people or throw up extra you know headwinds for boards but there are a lot of kids and i think if we could just even get to that place where this is a really big

deal we need to focus on this it should transcend the sort of usual politics that characterize this sector because i just don't when you see even the reactions to the scores that just were released like i don't think we are as an education community there yet and and we can ill afford we can ill afford this appreciate the feedback we'll definitely work on that i want to also talk about another piece of the data that we're looking at

[06:16:51] and that um the data team and the research team have found as they're analyzing this and looking to see why why are we in this space why are we seeing this level of drop what what can we better understand and what we know is attendance matters we've been talking about attendance since last spring since my very first board meeting with you in april we talked about the importance of attendance we have at the department launched the attendance matters va campaign we have provided school divisions at the start of this year with videos with family resources talking about no kid hungry and the importance of breakfast after the bell talking about that important trusted adult

[06:17:27] thinking about the barriers to transportation and other things that are getting in the way i know dr siebert's been working very hard and transportation might be a pain spot but we are continuing to work through those things and make sure that we have good things for our kiddos and thinking about attendance but one of the reasons that we have been focusing on attendance is because if we look at 2018-19 and we look at today our chronic absenteeism in particular in grades three through eight has almost doubled so our kiddos who are missing more than 18 days of school year and that seems like a lot like if i go talk to my daughter or go talk to friends 18

[06:18:01] days is almost a school month right but that's two days two days in august two days in september that's two days a month. So when we start talking about kiddos who are missing two days a month, doubling, that's a major impact into a classroom. That's a major impact to how a teacher teaches.

[06:18:19] That's a major impact into how students learn every single day. And what we know in that data is if I am chronically absent, my score drops on average 25% in math and 18% in reading. And this chart, which Dave really, really likes and is very important, and I appreciate the significant amount of calculations that went into it. That's an 18-day. If you drop down to 27, 36, and 54, you can see how unlikely it is the more days I miss, which is common sense, right? I'm not in

[06:18:57] school. I don't learn, but we need data to say, you know what? If you're not in school, you're not learning and it's even worse with mathematics if you are not in school you're not learning math it is essential for that high quality teacher to be physically in front of that student teaching every single day and we know that but during the pandemic we asked families to keep their children at home we asked families to keep their children safe and make sure that they were healthy before they came in and we changed the culture of school going so much so that twice as many children are staying home today so we have to change that message we have to change that expectation and we have to

[06:19:37] change what happens with students coming to school every single day and I've talked to a lot of people who are like oh yeah high school kids no I'm talking about grades three through eight our students in grades three through eight coming to school every day those students who are chronically absent doubled since pre-pandemic what we also know and talked about this are fragile student groups it's almost a one-to-one correlation in the attendance drops and in the performance drops of our most fragile students. So our most fragile students are not coming to school at a higher

[06:20:14] increment. So we have one in five Black students are chronically absent. One in five Hispanic students are chronically absent. And one in four economically disadvantaged and students with disabilities. So we are seeing increases in our student groups in the same way we're seeing increases in our others but it's impacting that gap in learning even more and so if we're thinking about the number one thing we can do to think about making sure our students are getting the learning and getting the programming and getting the impacts of the virginia literacy act we have

[06:20:51] to get students to come back to school and i i am going to shout our school divisions they are working very hard i have heard from multiple school divisions about hiring attendance clerks i've been to louisa county and they they make kiddos come to school the next day if they miss they schedule time there are a lot of school divisions working very hard but we also have to message it as a community we need to make sure our families understand our families understand kids have to come to school they have to be in school to learn we're doing great things in school and you have to come every day we have to talk to our pediatricians we have to think about those transportation barriers we have to as a community come together and really start talking about how

[06:21:28] important it is to be in school every single day to support our teachers and our schools and our school division with that message so i'm going to shift now to so what now what this data is concerning as you said this is a five alarm moment and what we know and what we understand and what we're seeing in the correlation because the first thing is what is a correlation what is another factor that we can correlate and attendance is a clear factor that we can correlate so that was It was the only denominator. We cut this data by region. We cut this data by different opportunities, different grade bands.

[06:22:02] The one thing that was very clear almost in a one to one correlation was the attendance component. So as we think about the opportunity and the money that General Assembly has given to school divisions to think about this, the 418 million dollars on top of the addition to salaries on to addition to the funding that goes in the general fund.

[06:22:24] about solutions. And one of the most impactful solutions that we're seeing across the country is high intensity tutoring. And we're seeing this across the board. Some school divisions are doing great tutoring work, some school divisions are doing some tutoring work, some school divisions are trying to figure that out. What we have released Tuesday, yesterday morning, is a high intensity tutoring playbook. And that playbook focuses on these five things: a one to 10 ratio, three to five hours a week, three different types of delivery models, either during the school, before and after, or using a combination of during the day intersession, using strong tutors

[06:23:03] and daily attendance in those tutoring sessions. This is based on Annenberg research. It is based also on the research that is happening in real time in multiple states across the country. You will see in the Annenberg research a lower student ratio. We have adapted that ratio because of the staffing issues in virginia and want to be responsive and respectful of the challenges school divisions have in staffing we also have worked really hard with school divisions and talked with them and they are recommending that three to five hour band because they know it's a little bit different and a little bit different needs in different school divisions we know that some

[06:23:39] school divisions can definitely do this during the day they can think about their modifying their schedule we've heard several principals say i i have this i can do that we've had other principals say we need the before and after model, because we don't have the opportunity to do that. We've also heard

loud and clear that I need some flexibility. Sometimes I need before, sometimes I need during, sometimes I need three days during Thanksgiving, a week over Christmas, two weeks at the end of the year to get that average of three to five weeks, but we need the flexibility and autonomy in our system to think through that. We also know that staffing has to be a diverse

[06:24:15] solution for school divisions. We know that some school divisions, there are teachers who want to work after school and gain a little bit of extra dollars. We know some teachers who want to work during their planning period and gain some extra dollars. We also know that there are some places we can't ask our teachers to continue to do more and more. And so we have to think about our retired teachers. We have to think about our teachers who may have exited, who might want to do some part-time work. And then we have made an all call for those volunteers, those community-based volunteers are folks who might be aspiring educators in our colleges our smart math people

[06:24:49] who are in colleges made a call to our deans of education on Monday to say we need partnerships our teams are standing up a website that allows people who want to volunteer to sign up and then school divisions to be able to access that sign up for volunteers and be able to coordinate that so it's a little bit more centralized and state level but we're not getting in the way of that coordination. And then the state is procuring a reading and a math content. That reading and math content is not your old digital practice, like your digital worksheet where Lisa's having a hard

[06:25:24] time in fractions, so she's going to do fractions until she gets fractions right. There's actually a lot of intuitive nature in our current digital content processes that if Lisa's having a hard time and she misses fractions two or three times, then Lisa can get a little AI tutor that says, hey, it looks like you're having a hard time with fractions. Let's help you think through fractions.

[06:25:44] But then it shoots a report out that says these are the lessons that the tutor should be working with Lisa on fractions so that Lisa can practice the fractions or the issues that she has and helps guide that tutor. So if I'm a community tutor or retired tutor or a teacher, I'm not doing a bunch of lesson planning for tutoring. That digital content actually provides guidance and support for the teacher or tutor content allows that personalized tutoring to happen at a much easier rate that is what the state is working towards in this focus around 70 of those 418 million dollars

[06:26:19] really digging in to a tutoring framework that's in the playbook but allowing school divisions to customize and be creative and think about what makes sense for them what they're already doing what they may need to include and where they need to go as they're thinking about these groups of students that need to work um bill you had your hand up i'm sorry yeah just a couple questions in terms of going back to the previous slides just the targeting of this this slide how are these funds going to be targeted um to address these students the general assembly allocated

[06:26:56] the funds um using free lunch so economically disadvantaged and adm so school divisions will receive allocations based on ADM and free lunch based on what the general assembly passed in their budget language and in terms of the timing of the dollars um have to be spent this academic year or is there flexibility in the next fall or what's the timing um the general assembly appropriated that i would need kent to come back and give me some detailed information since i've been so much on this side um but what we're trying to accomplish is part of the general assembly language asks for very specific information and reporting. So we're trying to put structures in

[06:27:34] place that allow school divisions to report in detailed ways, but in simplified ways so they can focus on the programming. But it is one-time funds. I guess my final question is on that latter point in terms of the accountability and the transparency of how the dollars are being spent and just even on the reporting of some of the best practices or if there's any way to have a clearinghouse of what's working the best in some districts that have maybe killed it and others that maybe the money wasn't spent very effectively, but we are going to stand up regional tutoring networks that allow school divisions instructional staff to share practices and share

[06:28:11] strategies across the board. We also have partner states who have done some of these things and pulling in some of those battle, you know, battle ready principals and school leaders and division instructional staff to come in and talk to ours. We've offered that as we're talking, but we are going from region to region to region and talking with superintendents and instructional teams over the next 10 days to really think through, listen, listen to the concerns, the struggles, and make sure that we're responding in ways that are in real time so that we give them a faster turnaround. For spending the money, we are asking for a spending plan that allows school divisions to put the money in the spending plan. And then we're trying to be able to allocate that money

[06:28:49] as tightly as possible to make reporting more of a fiscal nature than truly a back-end report. One last question, just in terms of the available teachers and others to do the tutoring, whether it's vendors or nonprofits or whomever locally, or is there going to be some type of, again, maybe a clearinghouse for some districts that maybe have a surplus and others who have a shortage, or how can you?

[06:29:15] That's what we're hoping to do with that portal. So on the front end of that portal, it'll be almost like a Google form where people can come in and say, I want a tutor. Our church group wants a tutor. Our dean of education has 45 aspiring educators who want to tutor. And then our superintendents can come in with their secure login and see what's available and contact those folks.

[06:29:37] we're trying to put together a fairly simple portal that we're not vetting per se, but we're allowing connectivity so people aren't going and door knocking and we don't have groups coming and going in the wrong places. Thank you. And just thank you for your team for getting on top of this so quickly. Dr. Kunz, I feel so appreciative and overwhelmed by the data. And the thing that want to just um i think double down on is the culture of staying home that is very much what

[06:30:16] is happening i appreciate your push around not it's just not an educator problem it's a workforce it's everything uh it's everyone coming together saying like we've got to get back the i guess the particularly the pediatricians i i appreciate that because um like i have kids who stay home for for just not feeling well um so it's like mental health it is like i have a soft cold or the undiagnosed things because of two years of a pandemic kids who have asthma it's like a compounding effect so i just appreciate you naming all those things because sometimes

[06:30:56] this is like just go to school it's actually a lot more complicated than that um the second thing and this is the work this is my second board meeting but everything that we're doing around data and accountability is connected to this because what i've seen to move the most is when parents see the data parents see the data that says you've missed these many days and this is the impact on learning it's it's it's clear to everybody so to the extent and we haven't i haven't heard that much about us talking about how this data becomes user-friendly to parents which then

[06:31:34] teachers are the biggest ambassadors for parents so it's got to be easy for teachers got to be easy for parents and then the last part um i'm wondering about this this pie is is the question that i have because i'm again just echoing so many things that you said is um one thing that i i think is a somewhat of a trap when you see the gaps around data is teachers think they have to do two years of teaching in one year while also teaching that exact same year so you're trying to teach three years in one year which sounds crazy because you can't do it and um so

[06:32:11] it's the coherence so when you're talking about fractions building on fractions it made me wonder what is the work we're doing around coherence from grade to grade so that tutors and teachers know like you need to get this skill because it's going to come around the corner really quick the next year round i think there's some of that working in the the things that the math teams are working on in coherence specifically around mathematics and that virginia literacy act and some of the things emily's working about on the curriculum side i think that's some of the most important things we're seeing in the new digital content that includes that ai because

[06:32:48] that ai is actually kind of directing that so they're saying you know you're a fourth grader here's your fourth grade content oh wait you don't know double digit addition this is essential to this fourth grade content and it's the acceleration work that is happening across the nation that it's not okay we're going to go all the way back to second grade and keep you at second grade and widen the gap right it's i show my age when i do this so i apologize but it's like when you do crochet and you have a drop stitch and crochet you've got to go down and pick that stitch up and pull it back up the challenge for our educators today is everybody has a different drop stitch

[06:33:25] so having some some data that kind of guides those tutors who are busy and who might not have that ability to see that allows them to know which stitch and which personalization happens in the tutoring and that's that sweet spot we're seeing an acceleration across the country versus that here's the ceiling come back practice here's the ceiling come back and practice and the simple way that people are terming that as remediation right so that stitch and pull up that acceleration that says oop you missed this lesson let me show you how it spirals back up to what you're learning today is incredibly important and we're seeing 1.5 times growth when people use an

[06:34:04] acceleration approach versus a remediation approach and those are on states like louisiana texas and tennessee who have been collecting this data since immediately post pandemic that acceleration approach is incredibly important and i think as you talked about networking school divisions together and thinking i think that's going to be a harder part of this shift and making sure that we're using an acceleration approach and what we're learning post-pandemic and some of the data collection that's happening thank you so if i may for a second um i wanted to just jump off on what you were talking about what miss ashton was talking

[06:34:40] about as it relates to parents and um you know i've said this over and over again something that we talk a lot about in early childhood is how are we going and meeting parents where they are because the data is absolutely critical to moving to in to truly investing parents in number one the understanding and once they understand the critical nature of the of the situation that we're in and and maybe the situation that their own child is in, the sooner that we're able to have those parents

[06:35:15] invested in moving the needle forward, not just for their children, but for the kids in the larger community. So, you know, I always kind of beat the pavement about how important it is to beat the

pavement, like footsteps, to knock doors, to get people to understand, to get parents to see this is the reality of this data so is there a way that we formulated a plan because we've got parents all over this this commonwealth that are working two three jobs we've got to find a way to meet them where they are and it's not necessarily from a facebook post and it's not necessarily from

[06:35:54] the flyer in the child's folder in their backpack like are we doing some really innovative things around communicating this to parents because they're on the ground and they're going to be the ones to help move this needle just as much as our teachers and our schools are.

[06:36:12] Yeah, so I have to shout out Delegate Coiner because she put legislation in place and formulated the parent task force, the parent portal task force. And one of the things there, I think the second meeting is on Thursday, right at the tail end of the board meeting. They're going to be talking about having national people come in and share different ways across the country people are doing parent portals in really innovative ways to like what you said. Here's their data, here's your attendance, here's those things. So I'm really excited about that group because they're really guiding us in what would be helpful. There are a lot of parents, a lot of stakeholders on that group to really help us think about what parents need. Second, I'm really excited because Melissa

[06:36:50] Rickey has come to the department over the past month and is launching our Office of Parent Engagement. So one of the things we're able to do with this data, the very night we did the announcement Thursday morning, the first lady took out flyers to families about how do you talk to your teacher? How do you ask questions about this data? What are the things you need to talk about? So it is a both and because the third strategy is we do have to be on Facebook. I promise you my daughter is on Facebook more than she sees anything in my grandson's backpack, right? So it is an and strategy. So we have started to put together resources that school

[06:37:27] divisions can turn key and push out on Twitter and push out on Facebook handouts, things that are important on family-friendly language that are coming through that parent engagement office that are thinking about what families need to hear and support families. But I'm going to flip to this slide a little bit because the third part of action three is all in on attendance. And so it is that chronic absenteeism campaign. It is gearing towards families. It is thinking about how we need to help families understand that, but it's also bringing people together. So I've had the opportunity to talk four or five times at different business chambers about the importance.

[06:38:05] I've had the opportunity to bring superintendents and business chambers together in different regions, but we also need to have other people at the table. We need the Virginia Association of Pediatrics. We need our transportation folks and our regulatory folks and our judicial folks.

[06:38:22] We need everybody to come together and say, oh, these are five things we can do right now to help this message, to help solve this problem. And so the secretary's office is leading this chronic absenteeism task force, and we're coming alongside, but making sure that we have a task force that actually gives cross-functioning regulations.

[06:38:41] It's not just on our school divisions, but it's all stakeholders working together and then packaging that in a playbook that says, these are the resources. these are the changes, these are the options that happen around chronic absenteeism to help with the attendance, to help change the messaging and support that work. I think it is an all-in approach, and I'm really proud of the all-in framing, because it's not this, it's not this, and that's what has been happening post-anthetic, and we have

to all come together. We have to have tutors, we have to have stakeholders talking about attendance, we have to think about the barriers that are happening and how do we remove those to ensure that families as mche know said know that

[06:39:20] it's a one-to-one when you come to school there's a difference change maker you've got great teachers in front of you great opportunities to learn and it's important for you to come and we know if they come they're more engaged there's more supports there's more resources to help all of those secondary factors that might happen so there is a clear focus on spending 10 of that 418 million on attendance for sure and being flexible depending on what school divisions need i i i particularly applaud the notion that messaging is a big part of it it's just

[06:39:54] and you know when we made a decision bill helped nudge us on the decision in the spring there was a suggestion from the department frankly your predecessor that we remove the chronic absenteeism indicator from accountability and we understood some reasons for that but we rejected it frankly because it was just terrible messaging at this crisis moment um i see that the white house actually put out something today about chronic absenteeism i know the department u.s department of education is all in on this messaging too and so my question uh is one one way to make the

[06:40:33] messaging powerful and effective is to make sure that it's everybody all in to what extent are we coordinating our messaging with the u.s department of education and the work they're doing on chronic absenteeism right now we're working with virginia to make sure we're supporting virginia and that's a great suggestion and happy to reach out because if we have everybody um from the president on down saying and across different perspectives then it's going to be much more unified and then my second question is um oh and because virginia frankly we're as awful as our attendance data is

[06:41:10] we're in one of the top states which is shocking you know that the national number is 30 percent chronic absenteeism compared to our virginia 20 which is and frankly ours probably as with our sol scores ours is probably better than the national average because it was so much better before the pandemic that even though we dropped significantly we're still well above national average but it so this is a national problem doubling though right it ours went from low to high and others went from high to higher um so we but we we we changed by a a significant margin and it is

[06:41:50] therefore you're right absolutely that we need to treat it as the crisis that it is but but to seeing it in the national context and seeing the solutions in the national context i think is useful um my question on the tutoring it seems brilliant except that the staffing issues and how possible you know how realistic is it and how quickly especially you know the three to five hours a week you know when the or how many kids and and is it are the divisions telling you they can make this and and it is going to have to be the defeat the divisions having to decide

[06:42:26] because they have the as i understand what the general assembly did they have the authority to use this money not the state they have to allocate this money as they see fit uh and they ramp it up quickly enough and are do they think they can ramp it up that's why we're going out one-time money that's why we are going out and talking to every single region and every single superintendent and their instructional teams and helping them problem solve i think when we preliminary talk to superintendents and started with five hours and one to five those shifts to one to ten and those

[06:43:01] shifts to three to five are in response to some of their conversations but our students deserve it we can't let our students continue to fall farther and farther behind so we have to come alongside our

school divisions and provide a ton of support the playbook that was released yesterday and making sure that we're problem solving with our superintendents but also providing the flexibility to think about who staffs that what makes sense for them when they offer that tutoring and giving them the flexibility to figure out that model within the context of their their schools and also giving them connectivity to people who have done it in the trenches in the schools and in the

[06:43:36] districts across the country to have places where they can think collaboratively about that and there are places across the country that have ramped up the high volume of high quality tutoring successfully on short notice and you're seeing them surpass their pre-pandemic scores miss ashton quick question one just don't forget the food lunch providers in that whole conversation because if food is good kids come to school that's right yep one and breakfast too breakfast raises attendance by six percentage points night and day and um so just one quick is the assumption based on 180

[06:44:14] school days yes okay yes yes it is yeah that's the federal expectation and the federal definition Dr. Northern did you have a question? Yeah and hopefully these are quick points. Are the kids made to attend or is it voluntary? There's compulsory attendance expectations in the state.

[06:44:34] I think what the school divisions will say is the ability to enforce compulsory attendance expectations is a challenge. Do you mean about tutoring? I mean about tutoring. Those are school division autonomy decisions for sure. So I mean I'm struggling honestly with the flexibility that we're allowing versus the um follow the evidence approach that we want to take so the flexibility all makes sense nobody wants to be told what to do um but you know the the research clearly says when we put these in place these volunteering things the kids that need the code don't come

[06:45:10] don't come we've been spending a lot of money on on tutoring and the right kids aren't coming and we've had like you know five seven percent eight percent of kids nationally that are going to tutoring that we need like eighty percent going so i am worried about this sort of voluntary like we can we're not going to make the kids show up i mean to the extent that we can think about really strong incentives uh to get the right kids to come i think would be important the other thing is the school location so the evidence says that it works better during school

[06:45:46] than before or after absolutely um and so i'm wondering and it works better obviously when you don't replace a core course so they can come during you know pe or art or some other elective um so is it the case that the school has to be the hub like so you can't like take you can't say your kid can go to sylvan learning and get tutored there we are providing recommendations based on on models across the state, based on the Annenberg research, we don't have the ability to tell school divisions what they must do around high dosage or high intensity tutoring. So they don't have to have it at the school is what you're saying. That's, you can't say that you have to. There's

[06:46:25] flexibility. The playbook gives best guidance. Like you said, during the day is the most impactful. The playbook talks about the options that are most impactful and recommends for school divisions, the best practice and evidence-based practice. Okay. I mean, some school divisions, for instance, might choose to spend their money on extended school day or extended school year the money the general assembly gave complete one-time money to the local school boards to allocate as they see fit so we're proselytizing to them and supporting them and facilitating this option but it's completely up to the local school boards if i understand what the what the general assembly did

[06:47:04] the time thing is exactly right i mean i was going to bring this up in the soqs like i think we need a longer school day i think we need more time period and if we got 180 days is kind of like hampering us right um i mean all kids need more time so um yeah i'm trying to figure out a way where we just have more time so i mean everybody needs to get tutored right like and if we i'm just really worried again that the kids are not going to show up for tutoring like we've just had a really hard time getting them there and we do all these great fabulous plans but if they're not going going to come, they're not going to come. So figuring out how to bake it in the school day,

[06:47:41] I think is really important. And it's strongly recommended. The during the school day and everybody I've talked to is trying to figure out during the school day, right? That is the emphasis and the focus of the school divisions as they're thinking about this. But obviously, you know, school has started. So what are some flexibilities that they have? As you said, extended year might be an option where they put those additional intercession days in to think through that. And that's why it's important for us to be side by side and helping school divisions problem solve and think through what their context is but reinforcing those things that matter and kind of like the absenteeism issue where we need more parents on board and need it better communicated

[06:48:19] you know it should be common sense why our children need to be at school but if you get that out the statistics as of why they need to be there wouldn't that be the same thing getting parents on board about their child getting tutored that's right you know working around their schedules and i mean if the parent says yes amber you need to be tutored you need the you know that that will help absolutely because schools can't force them to i also think and i'll bring this up tomorrow i also think experimenting with a value-added model for app for attendance would incentivize schools to your point to even get the kids there so they'll get credit the harder they try to get

[06:48:57] kids there they'll get credit in the accountability model that we're um developing so we can talk more about that later. But I think like, you know, all these ways that we can get some buy-in at the school and district level would help get kids there. Anything further? Dr. Haines, I do have one more question for you, or really a statement that you can agree with or correct me if I'm wrong.

[06:49:22] So the percentages that the governor outlined in the press conference the other day, about 70%, 20%, 10%, those are simply guidelines, correct? Strong recommendations. Strong recommendations. So if a school division said, well, I'd rather spend 80% in tutoring and, you know, 10% in the other two, that would be okay. Because they're already committing, maybe there are, they may already be committing funds to, let's say, targeting chronic absenteeism. And maybe they want to put a lot of emphasis in the tutoring, while they just add a little bit more to the other two that they are already working hard on.

[06:50:02] All right. Thank you. All I wanted to verify. Yes. Related to that is, I think, it comes in inherently with respecting the differences in the divisions. Serving now in an urban division, we have different opportunities, tighter attendance zones that can help with things. Also, some divisions like ours have already been investing very heavily in school social workers and truancy office, people going out there getting the kids into school.

[06:50:30] And so that effort is underway. I think, so that brings back to where I wanted to say, kudos. I also liked, it's kind of at the end, but I'd like to see us lift it up, that there is a parent responsibility piece here.

[06:50:46] We've had a lot of conversations, understandably, about parent rights. There is a parent responsibility here that I think needs to be messaged hard. Not just, here is the data, but by the way, this is your job. And that is hugely important. I think that excellent work like this should inform next work.

[06:51:05] And I think maybe this is where Dr. Northam was going with the SOQ conversation. Because truly, pre-pandemic, our SOQs didn't have to factor in many of these issues that do require school social workers. and attendance interventionists and things like that these these are absolute must-have positions now that again some divisions have a chance to invest in some divisions will now have a chance to invest in um but this this is going to endure uh beyond the year so so that a lot of us a lot of divisions i know spun this up using us for funds uh without going away this dose is going to help um but i do think uh the messaging about during the day is just key because at the end of

[06:51:43] the day kids are tired teachers are tired everybody's tired but there are ways to break out your schedule and this again what has to be it has to vary by division based on your your how spread out your kids are and what your concentrations are so those things are very very good but i hope we'll continue to talk about the parent responsibility piece and i think as we get to soq um we're going to think about these other positions that that these needs are not going away right away and we're going to continue to have people who are pounding the pavement getting kids in schools and that's going to be very very important back to incentivizing there's incentivizing in terms

[06:52:18] of the outcomes um which again i think the outcomes of student performance schools are all in on um if we're another way to incentivize attendance interventions is to actually give schools credit for when you do have the saturday program and you get the kids come in and you do the opportunities when you have you use the monday before uh a couple days before break or after a break a couple couple days during spring break or when you have meaningful engagement of that child out there right now attendance is is like it's easy it's one of our easiest things to measure because we're pretty arbitrary about it and so I think some some nuance there is going to be important because

[06:52:56] there's there's difference between being absent and being truant and and we we need more tools in the truancy category Mr. Rotherham go ahead go ahead yeah I wanted to pick up on something Dr.

[06:53:10] I think it's extremely important we differentiate between truant and chronically absent and in part because I worry we're creating an incentive here where schools, if they're like always got to move the numbers, they're going to find kids who may be chronically absent technically, but may not actually be struggling at the expense of going and finding their truants and like getting the kids who we know are really, you know, there are kids who miss a lot of school for whatever reason, but they're actually keeping up.

[06:53:36] they're fine, they're engaged, the parents know where they are, they're in no way. And, you know, we should take those cases, we should discuss that, but that is distinct from the truancy issue. The other comment, I just want to pick up on Dr. North, I think I like that we're sending out, so here's the best research and so forth. I get the 10 to 1, just given the constraints, it is obviously not ideal when the research says, you know, no more than four. And so just letting people know like the flexibility works both ways and so they do have flexibility actually has models that go to one to five and shows them how to do rotations on one to five yeah i encourage you to

[06:54:14] see the playbook because a lot of the things you guys are talking about are modeled in the playbook so how do you do it during the day there's four or five different master schedules and how you

can adapt a master schedule there are multiple examples of how to rotate children and actual visuals of rotating children. Totally agree. This is just the front page graphic. So I'm really proud of the work the team did to stand up a tutoring playbook so quickly. But there are a lot of models and examples that help think through, but that also require us to sit side by side with school divisions and say, so, okay, how does this work? So I totally agree. Sorry. Yeah. And I think that, yeah, so that was the last comment I just want to make. I think this is just a great opportunity.

[06:54:51] And like the fact that we were able to get this out relatively quickly, you know, relative timeline is great and and i do i just wanted to say that as well and i'm impressed that you're going to each school system each superintendent and they're you know working with each one because that has to make such a difference and just being told what to do miss halton one of the other things i know you're encouraging the superintendents recommending that they use their uh one-time flexible funding for is uh reading specialists and i raised with you the other day and maybe it's too new still to

[06:55:30] have that uh information but i'm concerned that one thing the general assembly apparently did not adequately address i think is the the reading specialists is needed for full implementation of the literacy act so we're talking about accelerating the vla but i'm worried about potential deceleration that the apparently the recommendation for full implementation of literacy act was 30 million dollars allocated to reading specialists and that was reduced in the final budget i'm told to six million dollars and i don't know if that's accurate information or not so i'm

[06:56:07] hoping we can find that out but if so that means the only dedicated money for vla reading specialists is that six million everything else is hoping that local divisions will use one-time money but one-time money to hire permanent employees is a tricky complicated trade-off so based on your comments lesson i asked emily to come back and she's going to come back and talk about that with marcy and they'll talk about the literacy act in october and give you some information on that and it may well i'm hoping help inform our soq recommendations and the governor's budget

[06:56:43] recommendations because i mean the most on the literacy stuff math has got to figure out how to address it too but literacy we have a solution we've just got to do it well um and it will help the upper grades eventually and we're you know we're we're talking grades four to eight etc but it's not going to happen if the divisions can't hire i mean a crucial piece of it as i understand is the interventionists in fact the reading specialists are crucial for the intervention but

[06:57:12] but also for the PD and support to the classroom instruction on the science of reading. So our classroom teachers aren't going to be able to implement without these reading specialists, or at least that's not, the plan is not, the plan includes reading specialists as a crucial part, component, as I understand it. And that's distressing if they're not fully funded.

[06:57:39] And I'm hoping we can use our SOQ conversations, among others, to do what we can to help influence that. Dr. Miller. Just last thought. This slide three, honestly, gives us all a pit in our stomach, right, where we see clearly that Virginia has lost more growth over the last five years than any other state.

[06:58:03] Like, I get that slide. Yeah. And I get, I mean, that's just objective data right there. You know, it's not meant to shame anybody. it's not meant to do anything but inform um and i find that just in my conversations with teachers friends like nobody really knows that virginia's so far behind the nation they don't know that we are like dead last in terms of the back prog i mean the back step that we've taken and so

i don't know i feel like that um is a really helpful slide i certainly haven't seen it anywhere in the media any of the any of the coverage i've seen um and i just feel like it's an important message to get

[06:58:40] out there just so people understand the um the depth of the problem and issue that we have without pointing fingers at anyone if i may respond amber i think it's incredibly important but it's also incredibly important that we be careful in our language about it because it's not accurate to say that we are the worst in the nation it is accurate to say we have backslid and that we've basically gone from being top in the nation to being about average and virginians want to be top in the nation and we think of our students as top in the nation and so helping the public i

[06:59:15] think you're absolutely right helping the public understand that over a significant time period we have slid from that top in the nation so i'm all about being accurate i'm a researcher so like when i say you started saying you start out saying we we dropped more but then you said we are worst in the nation and that's not accurate i mean we're we are bottom in terms of our growth in the last five years we've backslid more than any other state in the union in terms of our growth the last five years backslid significantly especially on the fourth grade numbers not quite so much on the eighth grade numbers but the but the uh the result is we are now at average and we don't want to be

[06:59:54] average we think of ourselves as top in the nation and we want to go back i would argue i would argue we're not average if not if you're using the nape as your we are at or above average on all four NAEP scores the past five years that NAEP's the NAEP's the one in yellow yeah but if you look at the uh that's the change if you look at what our fourth grade average reading score is it's at or above the NAEP I respectfully suggest if we're doing gymnastics to talk by our average when we have like a third of kids below basic in eighth grade which means functionally unprepared to

[07:00:31] survive in our commonwealth's civic life or political life we are part of the problem if we cannot just forthrightly say this is a crisis it was a problem before the pandemic which was you know the pandemic was nobody's fault it happened is made it into a crisis if we just can't forthrightly talk about that then we're part of the problem as well and that's why i've been calling it a crisis particularly based on our gaps since 2014. yeah and the gaps i mean the attention the gaps is super important pandemic exploded it you know but if you look at the average nape scores we are at or above

[07:01:09] average in all four and i i think that we have to know what our goals are we have to know our audiences and that there is actually no one message around this so i'm just going to push us to like the data is the data we can't we're not making it up but if we're going to be arguing over which message i just think that's a losing argument and we have to stay focused on the goals focus on the action focus on the strategy and come together and say we all agree something we have to do something

[07:01:45] about this data period and that is what i'm going to push us to say thank you dr coons i i think we all um i think we all agree that um having conversations about that data in a different way does nothing to get us to those goals. And I think we probably ought to simply agree to disagree if that's the position that we need to be in and look forward to how we are together

[07:02:18] going to make this system better for kids in Virginia, for families in Virginia, and for Virginia as a whole. So I look forward to doing that with everyone on this board as we really work to get towards progress and the best student outcomes in the nation. And we are certainly on that track and I'm so excited for the work that this board has undertaken up to this point and will certainly be undertaking as we move into the future. So that being said, we have some people

[07:02:57] who have some calls and other business that needs to be attended to later this afternoon. And so if there is nothing else from this board that needs to be addressed at this point I would request um that we would adjourn for the afternoon okay with anybody do you need any we had you as closing comments at the end but originally I just didn't make sure you weren't getting did you have anything else do you have anything else not today no are you sure yeah I'm

[07:03:34] Good. Okay. All right. Well, with that, I will accept a motion to adjourn. Okay. We are adjourned.

